# 외계행성 대기
# Exoplanetary Atmospheres

## Lecture 9: Vertical Thermal Structure of a Planetary Atmosphere III
## 2026 November 9 (Monday)

**Based on: Chapters 8 and 9 of Seager, *Exoplanet Atmospheres* (2010), and Chapter 4 of Heng, *Exoplanetary Atmospheres: Theoretical Concepts and Foundations* (2017)**

선광일 (Kwangil Seon)
KASI / UST

2026-11-08 20:00

# Outline – Lecture 9

The Adiabatic Temperature Profile (Continued)

The One-Dimensional T–P Profile

Temperature Retrieval

Opacities

Summary

# The dry adiabatic temperature gradient: First Law of Thermodynamics

Consider an air parcel of mass $M$, volume $V$, density $\rho = M/V$, temperature $T$, and pressure $P$ that expands or compresses **adiabatically** while rising in a hydrostatic atmosphere (Seager §9.7.2).

**Step 1: First Law of Thermodynamics** (conservation of energy for the parcel):

$$\mathrm{d}U = \mathrm{d}Q - \mathrm{d}W,$$

where $\mathrm{d}U$ is the change in internal energy, $\mathrm{d}Q$ is the heat added to the parcel, and $\mathrm{d}W$ is the work done *by* the parcel on its surroundings.

- **Adiabatic process:** no heat is exchanged with the surroundings, so $\mathrm{d}Q = 0$.
- **Internal energy** of an ideal gas of mass $M$:

  $$\mathrm{d}U = Mc_v\,\mathrm{d}T = M(c_p - R_s)\,\mathrm{d}T,$$

  where $c_v$ and $c_p$ are the specific heat capacities (per unit mass) at constant volume and constant pressure, and $R_s = k_\mathrm{B}/(\mu_m m_\mathrm{H}) = c_p - c_v$ is the specific gas constant ($\mu_m$: mean molecular weight, $m_\mathrm{H}$: hydrogen mass; $c_v, c_p, R_s$ all in $\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}K^{-1}}$).
- **Work done by expansion:** $\mathrm{d}W = P\,\mathrm{d}V$. Differentiating the ideal gas law $PV = MR_sT$ (with $M$ constant) gives $P\,\mathrm{d}V + V\,\mathrm{d}P = MR_s\,\mathrm{d}T$, so with $V = M/\rho$,

  $$\mathrm{d}W = P\,\mathrm{d}V = MR_s\,\mathrm{d}T - V\,\mathrm{d}P = MR_s\,\mathrm{d}T - \frac{M}{\rho}\,\mathrm{d}P.$$

# The “dry” adiabatic temperature gradient

**Step 2: Combine into** $\mathrm{d}U = -\mathrm{d}W$ (dividing out the parcel mass $M$):

$$M(c_p - R_s)\,\mathrm{d}T = -MR_s\,\mathrm{d}T + \frac{M}{\rho}\,\mathrm{d}P \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \boxed{\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}P} = \frac{1}{\rho c_p}}$$

**Step 3: Convert pressure to altitude** $z$ via hydrostatic equilibrium ($\mathrm{d}P = -\rho g\,\mathrm{d}z$, where $g$ is the gravitational acceleration; the parcel always shares the ambient pressure $P$, while keeping its own $T$ and $\rho$):

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}z} = \frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}P}\frac{\mathrm{d}P}{\mathrm{d}z} = \frac{1}{\rho c_p}(-\rho g) = -\frac{g}{c_p} \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \boxed{\Gamma_{\mathrm{dry}} \equiv -\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}z} = \frac{g}{c_p}}$$

where $\Gamma_{\mathrm{dry}} > 0$ is the **dry adiabatic temperature gradient** (or **adiabatic lapse rate**).

- **In terms of optical depth** ($\mathrm{d}\tau = -\kappa\,\mathrm{d}z$, with extinction $\kappa = \rho\kappa_m$ per unit length and $\kappa_m$ per unit mass):
  $\Gamma_\tau \equiv \dfrac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}\tau} = \dfrac{g}{\kappa(\tau)\,c_p}$.
- **In terms of pressure** (substituting $\rho = P/(R_s T)$ into $\mathrm{d}T/\mathrm{d}P = 1/(\rho c_p)$):

  $$\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{T} = \frac{R_s}{c_p}\frac{\mathrm{d}P}{P} \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \boxed{T \propto P^{R_s/c_p}} \qquad \left(\frac{R_s}{c_p} = \frac{2}{7} \text{ for a diatomic ideal gas}\right),$$

  so an adiabat is a straight line on a $\log T$–$\log P$ diagram.

# Latent heat and saturation of a condensing vapor

- **Latent heat:** the thermal energy absorbed or released by a substance during a **phase transition** (e.g. evaporation or condensation) **at constant temperature**. The **specific latent heat** $L$ ($\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$) is the latent heat per unit mass of the phase-changing substance (for water vapor at $0\,^\circ\mathrm{C}$, $L \simeq 2.5 \times 10^6\ \mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$).
- **Why "saturation" ($P_{\mathrm{sat}}(T)$ and $m_s(T,P)$)?**
  - Over a liquid or solid surface, molecules continuously escape into the gas (**evaporation**) and return to the condensed phase (**condensation**). When the two rates balance in **phase equilibrium**, the vapor reaches its maximum possible partial pressure at temperature $T$ — the **saturation vapor pressure** $P_{\mathrm{sat}}(T)$ (the gas is "saturated," i.e. completely full of vapor).
  - The corresponding maximum mass mixing ratio is the **saturation mixing ratio**

$$m_s(T,P) \equiv \frac{\text{mass of saturated vapor}}{\text{mass of dry gas}} \approx \frac{\mu_{\mathrm{v}}}{\mu_{\mathrm{d}}} \frac{P_{\mathrm{sat}}(T)}{P},$$

    the mass of condensing vapor per unit mass of dry gas ($\approx$ per unit total mass for a trace condensable vapor).
  - **Role in a rising parcel:** An unsaturated parcel ($m < m_s$) cools along the dry adiabat $\Gamma_{\mathrm{dry}}$ without condensing until it cools to the temperature where $m = m_s(T,P)$ (100% relative humidity; cloud base). Above this level, the parcel stays saturated, so any further cooling ($\mathrm{d}T < 0$) lowers $m_s(T)$ and forces the excess vapor ($-\mathrm{d}m_s > 0$) to **condense immediately**, releasing latent heat.

# The "moist" adiabatic temperature gradient: Derivation

When a saturated rising parcel (of dry-gas mass $M$) cools by $\mathrm{d}T < 0$ and condenses a vapor mass $M(-\mathrm{d}m_s) > 0$, the released **latent heat** warms the parcel (Seager §9.7.2, Eq. 9.70):

$$\mathrm{d}Q = -ML\,\mathrm{d}m_s > 0 \qquad (\text{or } \mathrm{d}q \equiv \mathrm{d}Q/M = -L\,\mathrm{d}m_s \text{ per unit mass of dry gas; } \mathrm{d}m_s < 0 \text{ as vapor condenses}).$$

**Step 1: Substitute $\mathrm{d}Q = -ML\,\mathrm{d}m_s$ into the First Law** ($\mathrm{d}U = \mathrm{d}Q - \mathrm{d}W$) and divide by $M$:

$$(c_p - R_s)\,\mathrm{d}T = -L\,\mathrm{d}m_s - \left(R_s\,\mathrm{d}T - \frac{1}{\rho}\,\mathrm{d}P\right) \quad \Longrightarrow \quad c_p\,\mathrm{d}T - \frac{1}{\rho}\,\mathrm{d}P = -L\,\mathrm{d}m_s.$$

**Step 2: Apply hydrostatic equilibrium** ($\mathrm{d}P = -\rho g\,\mathrm{d}z$) and the chain rule $\mathrm{d}m_s = (\mathrm{d}m_s/\mathrm{d}T)\,\mathrm{d}T$:

$$\left(c_p + L\frac{\mathrm{d}m_s}{\mathrm{d}T}\right)\mathrm{d}T = -g\,\mathrm{d}z \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \boxed{\Gamma_{\text{moist}} \equiv -\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}z} = \frac{g}{c_p}\,\frac{1}{1 + (L/c_p)(\mathrm{d}m_s/\mathrm{d}T)}}$$

# The moist adiabatic temperature gradient: Earth's troposphere

How do the numbers work out in Earth's lower troposphere ($g = 9.8\ \mathrm{m\,s^{-2}}$, $T \simeq 288\ \mathrm{K}$ [15 °C], $P \simeq 1$ bar)?

- **Specific heat capacity $c_p$ of dry air** (78% $N_2$, 21% $O_2$; diatomic $f = 5$, mean molecular weight $\mu_\mathrm{d} \simeq 28.97$):

$$R_s = \frac{k_\mathrm{B}}{\mu_\mathrm{d} m_\mathrm{H}} \simeq 287\ \mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}K^{-1}} \quad \Longrightarrow \quad c_p = \frac{f+2}{2} R_s = \frac{7}{2} R_s \simeq \mathbf{1004}\ \mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}K^{-1}},$$

  which gives the **dry adiabatic gradient**:

$$\Gamma_\mathrm{dry} = \frac{g}{c_p} = \frac{9.8\ \mathrm{m\,s^{-2}}}{1004\ \mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}K^{-1}}} \simeq 9.76 \times 10^{-3}\ \mathrm{K\,m^{-1}} \simeq \mathbf{9.8}\ \mathrm{K\,km^{-1}}.$$

- **Saturation mixing ratio slope** $\mathrm{d}m_s/\mathrm{d}T$ from the **Clausius–Clapeyron equation**:
  - Here $P_\mathrm{sat}(T)$ is the **saturation vapor pressure** (maximum partial pressure of the vapor in equilibrium with its liquid/solid phase at temperature $T$) and $\mu_\mathrm{v}$ is the **molecular weight of the condensing vapor** ($\mu_\mathrm{v} = 18.015$ for $H_2O$).
  - Since $m_s(T,P) \approx (\mu_\mathrm{v}/\mu_\mathrm{d})\, P_\mathrm{sat}(T)/P \simeq 0.622\, P_\mathrm{sat}(T)/P$ and $\mathrm{d}P_\mathrm{sat}/\mathrm{d}T = L P_\mathrm{sat}/(R_\mathrm{v} T^2)$:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}m_s}{\mathrm{d}T} \simeq \frac{L m_s}{R_\mathrm{v} T^2} \qquad \left(L \simeq 2.5 \times 10^6\ \mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}},\ R_\mathrm{v} = k_\mathrm{B}/(\mu_\mathrm{v} m_\mathrm{H}) \simeq 461.5\ \mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}K^{-1}}\text{: vapor gas constant}\right).$$

  - At $T = 288$ K and $P = 1$ bar, $P_\mathrm{sat} \simeq 17$ mbar so $m_s \simeq 0.0106\ \mathrm{kg\,kg^{-1}}$ ($10.6\ \mathrm{g\,kg^{-1}}$), giving

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}m_s}{\mathrm{d}T} \simeq \mathbf{4.0} \times \mathbf{10^{-4}}\ \mathrm{K^{-1}} \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \frac{L}{c_p}\frac{\mathrm{d}m_s}{\mathrm{d}T} \simeq 1.0 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \Gamma_\mathrm{moist} = \frac{\Gamma_\mathrm{dry}}{1 + (L/c_p)(\mathrm{d}m_s/\mathrm{d}T)} \simeq \mathbf{5.0}\ \mathrm{K\,km^{-1}}.$$

# The moist adiabatic temperature gradient: Earth and exoplanets

$$\Gamma_{\text{moist}} = \frac{g}{c_p} \frac{1}{1 + (L/c_p)(\mathrm{d}m_s/\mathrm{d}T)} < \Gamma_{\text{dry}} = \frac{g}{c_p}$$

- Because condensation releases latent heat as the parcel rises, a moist parcel cools **more slowly** with altitude than a dry parcel ($\Gamma_{\text{moist}} < \Gamma_{\text{dry}}$).
- **Earth's troposphere:**
  - dry adiabatic temperature gradient: $\Gamma_{\text{dry}} \simeq 9.8\,\text{K}\,\text{km}^{-1}$;
  - moist adiabatic temperature gradient: $\Gamma_{\text{moist}} \simeq 5\,\text{K}\,\text{km}^{-1}$;
  - typical average: $\simeq 6.5\,\text{K}\,\text{km}^{-1}$ (convection is partly moist and partly dry).
- Remarkably, Earth's radiative temperature profile is *stable* against dry convection, but *unstable* against moist convection — **latent heat release is what drives convection in Earth's troposphere**.
- **Exoplanets:** the same formula applies to whatever species condenses at the planet's temperature (e.g. $NH_3$, $CH_4$, $H_2O$, silicates, iron), using its own latent heat $L$ and saturation curve $m_s(T)$.

# The One-Dimensional T–P Profile: Conceptual overview

To determine the vertical thermal structure of an atmosphere in **radiative–convective equilibrium** (Seager §9.8.1), we solve **three equations for three unknowns** — $T(\tau)$, $P(\tau)$, and $I(\tau,\mu,\nu)$:

1. **hydrostatic equilibrium:** $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}P}{\mathrm{d}\tau} = \dfrac{g\rho}{\kappa} = \dfrac{g}{\kappa_m}$;
2. **radiative transfer equation:** $\mu\,\dfrac{\mathrm{d}I(\tau,\mu,\nu)}{\mathrm{d}\tau} = I(\tau,\mu,\nu) - S(\tau,\mu,\nu)$;
3. **energy equilibrium** in each layer, comparing the atmosphere's radiative temperature gradient $(-\mathrm{d}T/\mathrm{d}z)_{\mathrm{rad}}$ with a rising parcel's adiabatic gradient $\Gamma_{\mathrm{ad}} \equiv (-\mathrm{d}T/\mathrm{d}z)_{\mathrm{ad}}$ ($\Gamma_{\mathrm{dry}}$ or $\Gamma_{\mathrm{moist}}$):
   - **radiative equilibrium** $\left[\text{convectively stable, } (-\mathrm{d}T/\mathrm{d}z)_{\mathrm{rad}} < \Gamma_{\mathrm{ad}}\right]$: $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}F_{\mathrm{rad}}}{\mathrm{d}\tau} = 4\pi\int_0^\infty \kappa_\nu (J_\nu - S_\nu)\,\mathrm{d}\nu = 0$;
   - **convective equilibrium** $\left[\text{convectively unstable, } (-\mathrm{d}T/\mathrm{d}z)_{\mathrm{rad}} > \Gamma_{\mathrm{ad}}\right]$: $-\dfrac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}z} = \Gamma_{\mathrm{ad}}$

     $\left(\text{or } \dfrac{\mathrm{d}\ln T}{\mathrm{d}\ln P} = \nabla_{\mathrm{ad}} = \dfrac{R_s}{c_p} \text{ for a dry gas}\right)$.

**Iterative solution procedure:**

- **Step 1 (Initial guess):** Start from an analytical gray T–P profile (§9.6.3) using $T$- and $P$-dependent opacities $\kappa(T,P,\nu)$.
- **Step 2 (Radiative iteration):** Solve the three equations numerically, applying temperature corrections $\Delta T(\tau)$ until a radiative-equilibrium T–P profile satisfies all three equations.
- **Step 3 (Convective adjustment):** Test every altitude for convective stability; where unstable, replace $\mathrm{d}T/\mathrm{d}z$ with the adiabat $-\Gamma_{\mathrm{ad}}$ and iterate again so the radiative zone joins the adiabat smoothly.

# A radiative-equilibrium atmosphere: Equations, inputs, and outputs

In the radiative-equilibrium layers (Seager §9.8.2, Eqs. 9.71–9.73), we solve simultaneously:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}P}{\mathrm{d}\tau} = \frac{g\rho}{\kappa}, \qquad \mu \frac{\mathrm{d}I(\tau,\mu,\nu)}{\mathrm{d}\tau} = I(\tau,\mu,\nu) - S(\tau,\mu,\nu), \qquad \frac{\mathrm{d}F(\tau)}{\mathrm{d}\tau} = 4\pi \int_0^\infty \kappa(\tau,\nu)\left[J(\tau,\nu) - S(\tau,\nu)\right] \mathrm{d}\nu = 0$$

- **Outputs (3 unknowns solved simultaneously):**
  - Temperature profile $T(\tau)$ and pressure profile $P(\tau) \implies$ the vertical **T–P profile**;
  - Radiation field $I(\tau,\mu,\nu)$ at all depths $\implies$ the **emergent planetary spectrum** $I(0,\mu,\nu)$ at the top of the atmosphere comes out simultaneously with the T–P profile.
- **Inputs (model parameters and boundary conditions):**
  - **Surface gravity** $g$**:** known directly for transiting exoplanets (from measured mass $M_p$ and radius $R_p$).
  - **Interior temperature** $T_{\mathrm{int}}$**:** sets the upward internal heat flux $F_{\mathrm{int}} = \sigma_{\mathrm{R}} T_{\mathrm{int}}^4$ from the deep interior; taken from planetary thermal evolution models or treated as a free parameter.
  - **Incident stellar irradiation:** top-of-atmosphere downward beam $I_0(\nu)$ along direction $-\mu_0$.
  - **Opacities** $\kappa(\tau,\nu)$**:** depend on the chemical composition; requires input **elemental abundances** together with either **thermochemical equilibrium** or a **photochemical model** (Chapter 4).

# A radiative-equilibrium atmosphere: Why iteration is required

Why can't we solve the three radiative-equilibrium equations in a single step (Seager §9.8.2)?

- **Subtlety 1: Tight nonlinear coupling among $T$, $P$, chemistry, and $I_\nu$.**
  - Suppose we solve the radiative transfer equation alone for a trial $T(\tau)$, find that radiative equilibrium is violated ($\mathrm{d}F/\mathrm{d}\tau \neq 0$), and update $T(\tau)$ to restore radiative equilibrium.
  - Changing $T(\tau)$ alters the **chemical equilibrium number densities** $n_i(T,P)$ of absorbing molecules and atoms.
  - This changes the **gas pressure** $P(\tau)$ (via the equation of state and hydrostatic equilibrium) as well as the **opacities** $\kappa(\tau,\nu)$ and **emissivities** $\varepsilon(\tau,\mu,\nu)$.
  - Modified $\kappa(\tau,\nu)$ and $\varepsilon(\tau,\mu,\nu)$ in turn alter the **radiation field** $I(\tau,\mu,\nu)$ at *all* depths!

- **Subtlety 2: Non-locality introduced by scattering.**
  - When scattering is present in the source function $S(\tau,\mu,\nu)$, photons are not absorbed and re-emitted locally, so the radiation field $I(\tau,\mu,\nu)$ decouples from the local Planck function $B_\nu(T)$.
  - For an irradiated exoplanet, incident stellar photons can scatter multiple times and travel deep into the atmosphere before being absorbed and heating the gas — directly coupling the top of the atmosphere to the deep layers.

- **Consequence:** A simultaneous, iterative numerical solution is essential, starting from a physically reasonable initial guess (such as the analytical gray T–P profile).

# Radiative–convective equilibrium: Convective adjustment

Once a radiative-equilibrium profile $T_{\rm rad}(z)$ is obtained, we check if the atmosphere is stable against convection, using the **Schwarzschild criterion** (Seager §9.8.3):

$$\left|\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}z}\right|_{\rm rad} > \left|\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}z}\right|_{\rm ad} \equiv \Gamma_{\rm ad} \qquad \Longleftrightarrow \qquad \text{convectively unstable!}$$

- **Dominant-convection approximation:** In planetary atmosphere models, whenever convection sets in, it is usually assumed to be so efficient that it dominates energy transport and forces the temperature gradient to follow the **adiabatic temperature gradient** directly ($\mathrm{d}T/\mathrm{d}\tau = \Gamma_\tau = g/[\kappa(\tau)c_p]$, which already incorporates hydrostatic equilibrium).
- **Fixing the integration constant (boundary condition):**
  - The adiabatic gradient fixes only the *slope* of $T(z)$ or $T(P)$ (giving a family of parallel adiabats, $T \propto P^{R_s/c_p}$).
  - To make the convective profile consistent with the overlying radiative zone, we match $T$ to the **radiative-equilibrium temperature at the top of the convection zone** (the radiative–convective boundary, RCB), assuming convection carries the full upward energy flux ($F_{\rm rad} \approx 0$):

$$F_{\rm conv}(\tau) = \underbrace{\sigma_{\rm R} T_{\rm int}^4}_{\text{internal heat flux}} + \underbrace{\mu_0 I_0}_{\text{absorbed stellar flux}}$$

(or $F_{\rm conv} = \sigma_{\rm R} T_{\rm int}^4$ if starlight is absorbed above the RCB).

# Radiative–convective equilibrium: Convective heat flux

In transition regions where **both radiation and convection** transport significant fractions of the energy (Seager §9.8.3), radiative equilibrium is replaced by total flux conservation:

$$\boxed{F_{\rm rad}(\tau) + F_{\rm conv}(\tau) = \sigma_{\rm R} T_{\rm int}^4 + \mu_0 I_0 \ \left( \equiv \sigma_{\rm R} T_{\rm eff}^4 \right)}$$

(Note: Seager Eq. 9.76 writes $\sigma_{\rm R} T_{\rm eff}^4 + \mu_0 I_0$, carrying over $T_{\rm eff}$ from unirradiated stellar atmospheres in place of $T_{\rm int}$; for an irradiated planet, $\sigma_{\rm R} T_{\rm eff}^4 \equiv \sigma_{\rm R} T_{\rm int}^4 + \mu_0 I_0$ is the total outgoing thermal flux when $\mu_0 I_0$ is deposited below.)

**Expression for the convective heat flux** $F_{\rm conv}$ (Eqs. 9.77–9.78):

- A rising convective mass element of density $\rho$ and specific heat $c_p$ that is warmer than its surroundings by $\Delta T$ deposits excess thermal energy $\rho c_p \Delta T$ per unit volume when it merges with the ambient atmosphere. Moving upward at mean speed $\bar{v}$, it carries a heat flux

$$\boxed{F_{\rm conv} = \bar{v}\, \rho c_p \Delta T, \qquad \Delta T = \left[ \left( -\frac{{\rm d}T}{{\rm d}z} \right) - \left( -\frac{{\rm d}T}{{\rm d}z} \right)_{\rm c} \right] \Delta z}$$

  where $(-{\rm d}T/{\rm d}z)$ is the temperature gradient of the surrounding atmosphere (in radiative–convective equilibrium) and $(-{\rm d}T/{\rm d}z)_{\rm c}$ is the internal temperature gradient of the rising convective element over distance $\Delta z$.

# Radiative–convective equilibrium: Mixing-length theory

To evaluate the convective flux

$$F_{\text{conv}} = \bar{v}\,\rho c_p \Delta T = \bar{v}\,\rho c_p \left[ \left( -\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}z} \right) - \left( -\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}z} \right)_{\mathrm{c}} \right] \Delta z,$$

what quantities are known and what remains to be modeled (Seager §9.8.3)?

- **Known or solved-for quantities:**
  - Specific heat capacity $c_p$ is known from gas composition;
  - Temperature $T(z)$ is the variable being solved for;
  - Density $\rho(T, P)$ follows from the ideal gas law and hydrostatic equilibrium.
- **Remaining unknowns:** the mean convective velocity $\bar{v}$, the internal gradient $(-\mathrm{d}T/\mathrm{d}z)_{\mathrm{c}}$, and the travel distance $\Delta z$ before the element dissolves into its surroundings.
- **Mixing-length theory (MLT):**
  - Borrowed from stellar astrophysics (Böhm-Vitense 1989; Mihalas 1978), MLT is a **local 1D approximation** used because no definitive 3D analytical theory of convection is available.
  - Its key parameter is the **mixing length** $l = \Delta z$, the characteristic vertical distance a convective bubble rises before releasing its excess heat and sinking again — typically chosen to be comparable to the pressure scale height, $\boxed{l \sim H}$.

# What is Collision-Induced Absorption (CIA)?

- **Why isolated $H_2$, He, and $N_2$ are infrared-inactive:**
  - Symmetric homonuclear diatomic molecules ($H_2$, $N_2$) and noble-gas atoms (He) have **zero permanent electric dipole moment** (their electron cloud is symmetric).
  - By quantum selection rules, an isolated $H_2$ or $N_2$ molecule therefore cannot absorb infrared photons via electric-dipole rotational or vibrational transitions.
- **How collisions induce infrared absorption:**
  - During a close binary encounter (e.g. $H_2$–$H_2$, $H_2$–He, or $N_2$–$N_2$), intermolecular forces distort the electron clouds and create a **transient (temporary) electric dipole moment** for the duration of the collision ($\Delta t \sim 10^{-13}$ s).
  - While colliding, the pair can absorb an infrared photon (**collision-induced absorption, CIA**). Because $\Delta t$ is extremely short, Heisenberg uncertainty ($\Delta\nu \sim 1/[2\pi\Delta t]$) broadens CIA into smooth **infrared continuum opacity** (crucial in giant planets, brown dwarfs, and Titan).
- **Why CIA opacity scales with pressure ($\kappa_m \propto P \implies \tau \propto P^2$):**
  - Because CIA requires **two-body collisions**, the volume absorption coefficient scales as the number density squared: $\kappa \propto n^2 \propto \rho^2$.
  - Hence the mass opacity scales linearly with density/pressure, $\boxed{\kappa_m = \kappa/\rho \propto \rho \propto P}$, and hydrostatic equilibrium ($d\tau = [\kappa_m/g]\,dP \propto P\,dP$) yields $\boxed{\tau \propto P^2}$.

# Is the deep atmosphere convective? Milne's solution and CIA

Write the Schwarzschild criterion in logarithmic form: the atmosphere is convectively stable if

$$\frac{\partial \ln T}{\partial \ln P} \leq \nabla_{\rm ad} = \frac{R_s}{c_p} = \frac{2}{2+f},$$

where $f$ is the number of degrees of freedom of the dominant gas: for a diatomic gas ($H_2$ on giant planets; $N_2$ on Earth and Titan), $\nabla_{\rm ad} = 2/7 \approx 0.286$ (translation + rotation, $f = 5$) or $1/4 = 0.25$ (with vibration activated, $f = 6$).

Deep in the atmosphere ($\tau \gg 1$), internal heat gives Milne's radiative solution, $T^4 \propto \tau$:

- **Constant opacity ($\kappa_m = $ const):** $\tau \propto P \implies T \propto P^{1/4}$, so $\dfrac{\partial \ln T}{\partial \ln P} \to \dfrac{1}{4} \leq \dfrac{2}{7}$: **convectively stable** (remains radiative).
- **Collision-induced absorption (CIA) dominates ($\kappa_m \propto P$):** $\tau \propto P^2 \implies T \propto P^{1/2}$, so $\dfrac{\partial \ln T}{\partial \ln P} \to \dfrac{1}{2} > \dfrac{2}{7}$: **unconditionally convective!**

This result is independent of absorption strength, scattering, or gravity $g$: whenever CIA dominates deep down, the interior of a gas giant *must* convect.

Higher up, strong stellar irradiation tends to stabilize the T–P profile, though a strong greenhouse ($\kappa_{\rm vis} \ll \kappa_{\rm ir}$) can produce detached convective zones between radiative layers.

# Temperature Retrieval: Forward vs. inverse problems

- **The forward problem:**

$$\text{Inputs } \left(g, F_*, \text{abundances}, \kappa_\nu\right) \xrightarrow{\text{iterative solver}} \text{T–P profile } T(P) \longrightarrow \text{Emergent spectrum } F_\nu(0).$$

- **The inverse problem — "Temperature & Abundance Retrieval":**

$$\text{Observed spectrum } F_\nu(0) \xrightarrow{\text{retrieval}} \text{T–P profile } T(P) \text{ and molecular abundances.}$$

- **Solar System planets vs. Exoplanets:**
  - **Solar System planets:** High-resolution, high-S/N spectra allow one to infer a good initial (*fiducial*) T–P profile directly from the data, and then apply small perturbations to $T(P)$ and molecular abundances until the spectrum is fit.
  - **Exoplanets:** Spectra have much lower S/N and spectral coverage, so no unique fiducial T–P profile can be read off from the data. Instead, we must computationally explore the full parameter space to map out the **allowed ranges** of T–P profiles and atomic/molecular abundances.

- **Why a parametric T–P profile is needed (Madhusudhan & Seager 2009):**
  - Self-consistent forward radiative–convective models are far too computationally expensive to run $10^5$–$10^7$ times.
  - Instead, one uses a fast **parametric T–P profile** (run tens of thousands of times or more) while enforcing **hydrostatic equilibrium** and **global energy balance** — constraining the allowed T–P range, molecular abundances, Bond albedo, day–night energy redistribution, and effective temperature $T_{\rm eff}$.

# A parametric T–P profile: Mathematical formulation

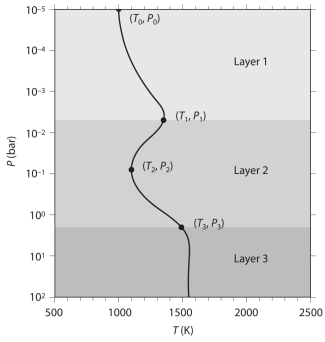



Figure 1: Parametric P–T profile with a thermal inversion in Layer 2 and an isothermal deep Layer 3. Seager (2010), Fig. 9.8, after Madhusudhan & Seager (2009).

Motivated by basic atmospheric physics, Solar System profiles, and 1D forward models, Madhusudhan & Seager (2009) parameterize pressure $P$ (in bar, used as the vertical coordinate) as a generalized exponential of $T$ (in K) across three layers (Seager §9.9, Eqs. 9.79–9.80):

$$\begin{aligned}
&\text{Layer 1} \quad (P_0 < P < P_1): \quad P = P_0\, e^{\alpha_1 (T-T_0)^{\beta_1}} \\
&\text{Layer 2} \quad (P_1 < P < P_3): \quad P = P_2\, e^{\alpha_2 (T-T_2)^{\beta_2}} \\
&\text{Layer 3} \quad (P > P_3): \quad T = T_3 \quad \text{(isothermal)}
\end{aligned}$$

**Counting the free parameters (from 11 down to 6):**

- Initially there are 11 parameters: $P_0, T_0, \alpha_1, \beta_1, P_1, P_2, T_2, \alpha_2, \beta_2, P_3, T_3$.
- Empirically $\beta_1$ and $\beta_2$ are redundant and fixed to $\beta_1 = \beta_2 = 0.5$ (leaving 9 parameters).
- The top of the model atmosphere is fixed at $P_0 = 10^{-5}$ bar (leaving 8 parameters).
- Requiring **temperature continuity** at the two layer boundaries ($P_1$ between Layers 1 & 2, and $P_3$ between Layers 2 & 3) eliminates 2 more parameters:

$$\begin{aligned}
T_1 &= T_0 + \left[\ln(P_1/P_0)/\alpha_1\right]^2 = T_2 + \left[\ln(P_1/P_2)/\alpha_2\right]^2, \\
T_3 &= T_2 + \left[\ln(P_3/P_2)/\alpha_2\right]^2.
\end{aligned}$$

- This leaves **6 free parameters** (e.g. $T_0, \alpha_1, \alpha_2, P_1, P_2, P_3$).

# A parametric T–P profile: Physical meaning of each layer

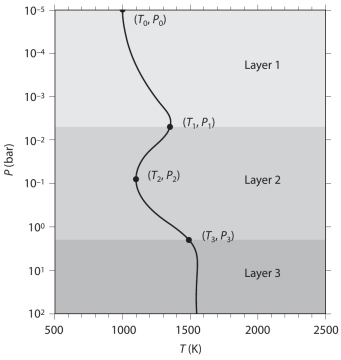



Figure 2: Three-layer parametric P–T profile (Seager 2010, Fig. 9.8).

Each layer in Figure 9.8 reflects the dominant physical regime at that depth (Seager §9.9):

- **Above Layer 1 ($P < P_0 = 10^{-5}$ bar):** Optical depth is very small at all wavelengths ($\tau_\nu \ll 1$); the atmosphere is virtually transparent to incoming and outgoing radiation and produces no significant spectral features.
- **Layer 1 ($P_0 < P < P_1$, upper atmosphere):** No thermal inversion; heated from below by the lower layers and cools upward with increasing altitude ($T$ decreases as $P$ decreases).
- **Layer 2 ($P_1 < P < P_3$, photosphere / stratosphere):** Optically thin-to-moderate region where **most spectral absorption and emission features are formed**. Governed by radiative processes (and atmospheric dynamics). A **thermal inversion** ($P_2 > P_1$, as drawn) can form here when strong stellar irradiation meets strong optical/UV absorbers (gases or haze particles).
- **Layer 3 ($P > P_3$, deep radiative-diffusion zone):** High optical depth ($\tau \gg 1$) prevents stellar radiation from penetrating directly; radiative diffusion yields a nearly **isothermal** structure ($T = T_3$) heated by interior energy outflow. **Below Layer 3**, high pressure/density produces high opacity, making **convection** the dominant transport mechanism.
- **Cooler planets (vs. hot Jupiters):** The isothermal Layer 3 is absent, Layer 2 extends deeper, and the radiative–convective boundary lies at higher altitude (lower $P$), so convection makes the profile in Layers 2–3 follow an **adiabat**.

# Opacities: Overview and Physical Role

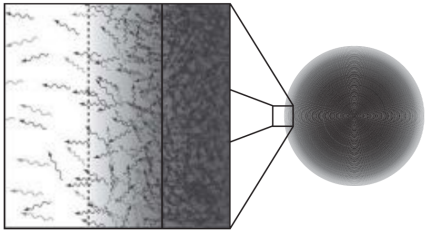


Figure 3: Photons emerging from a giant planet atmosphere are heated from below by the planetary interior ($T_{\rm int}$) and irradiated from above by the host star. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.1.

- **Why opacities matter:** Opacities govern how radiation is absorbed, emitted, and scattered throughout an atmosphere — controlling the vertical T–P profile, the onset of convection, and every spectral feature observed in planetary transmission, thermal emission, and reflection spectra.
- **Total monochromatic absorption coefficient (Eq. 8.1):**

$$\alpha(T,P,\nu) = \sum_j \sum_i n_{ji}(T,P)\,\sigma_{ji}(T,P,\nu)$$

  where $n_{ji}(T,P)$ is the number density of species $j$ in state $i$ and $\sigma_{ji}(T,P,\nu)$ is the transition cross section.

- **Dominant opacity sources at planetary temperatures:**
  - **Roto-vibrational molecular lines** (near- and mid-infrared);
  - **Electronic atomic & molecular lines** (UV and visible);
  - **Rayleigh scattering** by gas molecules and **condensate clouds/hazes**;
  - **Continuum opacities:** collision-induced absorption (CIA), bound-free, and free-free absorption.

# Spectroscopic Units and the Schrödinger Equation

- **Spectroscopic wavenumber:** Molecular spectroscopists measure transitions in **wavenumber** $\tilde{\nu}$ ($\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$), which is directly proportional to photon frequency $\nu$ and transition energy $\Delta E = E_{\text{upper}} - E_{\text{lower}}$:

$$\tilde{\nu} \equiv \frac{1}{\lambda} = \frac{\nu}{c} = \frac{\Delta E}{hc} \qquad \left(\lambda = 1\,\mu\text{m} \iff \tilde{\nu} = 10{,}000\ \text{cm}^{-1}, \quad \lambda = 10\,\mu\text{m} \iff \tilde{\nu} = 1{,}000\ \text{cm}^{-1}\right)$$

  - **Caution on terminology:** Do not confuse the spectroscopic wavenumber $\tilde{\nu} \equiv 1/\lambda$ (units of $\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$, waves per unit length) with the **angular (or circular) wavenumber** $k \equiv 2\pi/\lambda = 2\pi\tilde{\nu}$ ($\text{rad}\,\text{m}^{-1}$) widely used in physics and wave optics; they differ by a factor of $2\pi$.

- **Time-independent Schrödinger equation:** An atom or molecule absorbs or emits a photon of energy $h\nu = \Delta E$ only when jumping between discrete, quantized internal energy states. The allowed energy eigenvalues $E_i$ and stationary wave functions $\psi_i(\mathbf{r})$ are solutions of

$$H\psi_i = E_i\psi_i, \qquad H = -\frac{\hbar^2}{2m}\nabla^2 + V(\mathbf{r}), \qquad \nabla^2 = \frac{\partial^2}{\partial x^2} + \frac{\partial^2}{\partial y^2} + \frac{\partial^2}{\partial z^2}$$

  where $H$ is the Hamiltonian operator (kinetic energy $-\frac{\hbar^2}{2m}\nabla^2$ plus electrostatic potential energy $V(\mathbf{r})$) and $\hbar \equiv h/(2\pi)$.

# Atomic Energy Levels: The Hydrogen Atom

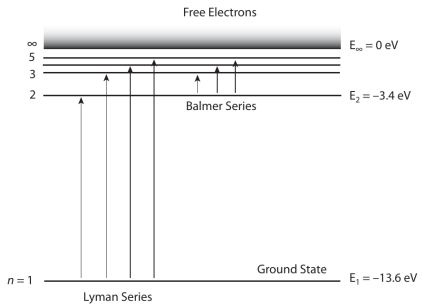



Figure 4: Hydrogen atom energy level diagram showing the Lyman ($n \to 1$), Balmer ($n \to 2$), and Paschen ($n \to 3$) series up to the 13.6 eV ionization limit. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.2.

- **Hydrogen atom energy eigenvalues:** For a single electron of mass $m_e$ in the Coulomb potential $V(r) = -e^2/(4\pi\varepsilon_0 r)$ of a proton, solving the Schrödinger equation yields discrete bound-state energies labeled by the **principal quantum number** $n = 1, 2, 3, \ldots$:

$$\boxed{E_n = -\frac{m_e e^4}{8\varepsilon_0^2 h^2}\frac{1}{n^2} = -\frac{R_{\rm H} hc}{n^2} = -\frac{13.6\ \text{eV}}{n^2}}$$

  where $R_{\rm H} = 1.097 \times 10^7\ \text{m}^{-1}$ is the Rydberg constant.

- **Bound-bound vs. bound-free transitions:**
  - Transitions between discrete levels ($n \leftrightarrow n'$) produce sharp **bound-bound** spectral lines (Lyman in UV, Balmer in optical, Paschen in near-IR).
  - Photons with $h\nu > |E_n|$ eject the electron into the continuum ($E > 0$), producing continuous **bound-free photoionization** opacity.
  - In multielectron atoms (e.g. Na I, K I in hot Jupiters), inner electrons screen the nuclear charge and split energy levels by orbital ($l$) and spin ($s$) angular momentum.

# Molecular Energy Levels: Born–Oppenheimer Hierarchy

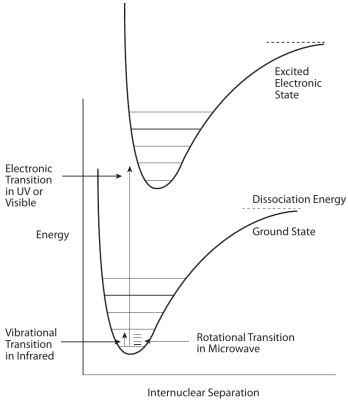



Figure 5: Schematic diagram of molecular electronic states (ground vs. excited), vibrational states ($v$), and rotational sublevels ($J$). Seager (2010), Fig. 8.3.

- **Why molecules dominate planetary spectra:** At planetary atmospheric temperatures ($T \sim 50$–$2500$ K), most elements are bound into molecules rather than free atoms, and thermal infrared photons match molecular vibrational and rotational energy spacings.
- **Born–Oppenheimer separation of energy scales:** Because electrons are $10^4$–$10^5$ times lighter than atomic nuclei, electronic, vibrational, and rotational motions separate cleanly:

$$E_{\rm total} \simeq E_{\rm el} + E_{\rm vib} + E_{\rm rot}, \qquad \Delta E_{\rm el} \gg \Delta E_{\rm vib} \gg \Delta E_{\rm rot}$$

  - **Electronic transitions:** $\Delta E_{\rm el} \sim \hbar^2/(m_e a^2) \sim 1$–$10$ eV ($\tilde{\nu} \sim 10^4$–$10^5$ cm$^{-1}$, **UV / visible**);
  - **Vibrational transitions:** periodic stretching/bending of bonds, $\Delta E_{\rm vib} \sim 0.1$ eV ($\tilde{\nu} \sim 500$–$4000$ cm$^{-1}$, **near- / mid-infrared**);
  - **Rotational transitions:** end-over-end rotation, $\Delta E_{\rm rot} \sim 10^{-3}$ eV ($\tilde{\nu} \sim 1$–$100$ cm$^{-1}$, **far-infrared / microwave**).

# Molecular Transitions: The Electric Dipole Requirement

To couple strongly to the oscillating electric field of an electromagnetic wave during rotation or vibration, a molecule must possess an asymmetric charge distribution — a nonzero **electric dipole moment** $\boldsymbol{\mu}_e = \sum_k q_k \mathbf{r}_k$:

- **1. Molecules with a permanent electric dipole moment:**
  - Asymmetric molecules such as **$H_2O$** (bent), **CO**, **$NH_3$** (pyramidal), **$O_3$** (bent), **HCN**, and **HF** have a permanent separation between the centers of positive and negative charge.
  - They exhibit **both pure rotational spectra** (far-IR/microwave) and **ro-vibrational spectra** (near-/mid-IR).
- **2. Symmetric polyatomic molecules with a vibrationally induced dipole moment:**
  - Symmetric linear (**$CO_2$**) or tetrahedral (**$CH_4$**) molecules have **zero permanent dipole moment** in their equilibrium geometry, and therefore **no pure rotational dipole spectrum**.
  - However, asymmetric stretching or bending vibrations temporarily break the charge symmetry and induce an oscillating dipole moment ($\partial \boldsymbol{\mu}_e / \partial q_k \neq 0$), producing **intense infrared ro-vibrational absorption bands**.
- **3. Symmetric homonuclear diatomic molecules ($H_2$, $N_2$, $O_2$):**
  - Their charge distribution remains completely symmetric both at rest and during bond stretching ($\boldsymbol{\mu}_e = 0$ always), so they have **no electric-dipole rotational or ro-vibrational spectrum** (absorbing in the IR only via weak electric-quadrupole transitions or **collision-induced absorption**).

# Molecular Rotational Transitions: Classical and Quantum Rigid Rotor

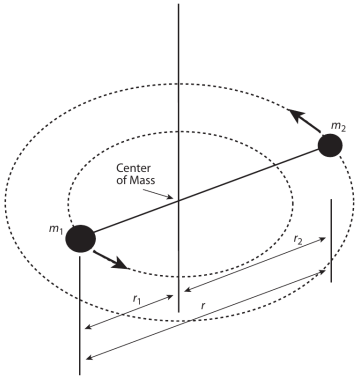



Figure 6: Diatomic molecule modeled as a rigid rotor: two masses $m_1, m_2$ at fixed separation $r = r_1 + r_2$ rotating about their center of mass. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.4.

- **Classical rigid rotor mechanics:** Two nuclei $m_1, m_2$ at fixed bond length $r = r_1 + r_2$ rotate about their center of mass ($m_1 r_1 = m_2 r_2$) at angular velocity $\omega$:

$$I = m_1 r_1^2 + m_2 r_2^2 = \mu r^2, \qquad E = \frac{1}{2} I \omega^2 = \frac{L^2}{2I}, \qquad L = I\omega,$$

where $I$ is the moment of inertia, $\mu \equiv m_1 m_2/(m_1 + m_2)$ is the reduced mass, and $L$ is the angular momentum.

- **Quantum rigid rotor eigenvalues:** With $V = 0$, the Schrödinger equation $\dfrac{L^2}{2I}\psi = E_{\rm rot}\psi$ has spherical harmonic eigenfunctions $Y_{J,m}(\theta, \phi)$ with $L^2 Y_{J,m} = J(J+1)\hbar^2 Y_{J,m}$, yielding

$$\boxed{E_J = BJ(J+1), \quad B \equiv \frac{\hbar^2}{2I}, \quad g_J = 2J+1 \quad (J = 0, 1, 2, \ldots)}$$

where $B$ is the **rotational constant** and $g_J = 2J+1$ is the magnetic sublevel degeneracy ($m_J = -J, \ldots, +J$).

# Rotational Selection Rules, Line Spacing, and Centrifugal Distortion

- **Electric-dipole selection rule and equally spaced rotational lines:**
  - Because a photon carries one unit of angular momentum ($\hbar$), dipole-allowed pure rotational transitions obey the selection rule $\boxed{\Delta J = \pm 1}$ ($\Delta J = +1$ for absorption, $\Delta J = -1$ for emission).
  - The photon energy absorbed in jumping from lower level $J-1$ to upper level $J$ ($J = 1, 2, 3, \ldots$) is

$$\boxed{\Delta E = E_J - E_{J-1} = B\big[J(J+1) - (J-1)J\big] = 2BJ}$$

  - Consequently, a pure rotational spectrum consists of a picket fence of lines with **constant spacing** $\Delta(\Delta E) = 2B$ in energy (or $\Delta\tilde{\nu} = 2B/[hc]$ in wavenumber).
  - **Example (CO):** With $m_C = 12\,m_H$, $m_O = 16\,m_H$, and bond length $r \simeq 1.13\,\text{Å}$, the $J = 0 \to 1$ transition lies in the millimeter/microwave regime ($\tilde{\nu} = 2B/[hc] \simeq 3.85\ \text{cm}^{-1}$, $\lambda \simeq 2.6$ mm; Seager quotes $B/[hc] \sim 0.7\ \text{cm}^{-1}$ as a typical order of magnitude).

- **Non-rigid rotor — centrifugal distortion at high $J$:**
  - Chemical bonds are not perfectly rigid rods: as a molecule rotates faster at high $J$, **centrifugal force stretches the bond length** $r$, increasing the moment of inertia $I = \mu r^2$ and slightly reducing the rotational spacing:

$$E_J \simeq BJ(J+1) - DJ^2(J+1)^2 \qquad (D \ll B\text{: centrifugal distortion constant}).$$

# Molecular Vibrational Transitions: Simple Harmonic Oscillator

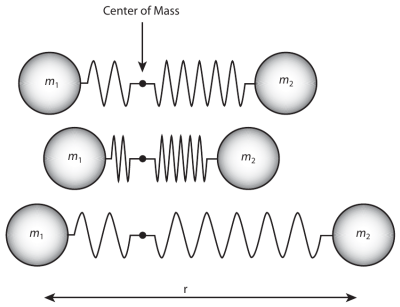



Figure 7: Diatomic molecule modeled as two masses connected by a spring of force constant $C$, vibrating in a parabolic harmonic potential $V(x) = \frac{1}{2}Cx^2$ with equally spaced levels $E_v = (v + \frac{1}{2})h\nu_0$. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.5.

- **Simple harmonic oscillator (SHO) model:** Near the equilibrium bond length $r_e$, the restoring force obeys Hooke's law $F = -Cx$ ($x \equiv r - r_e$; $C$: bond force constant), giving a parabolic potential $V(x) = \frac{1}{2}Cx^2$ and classical oscillation frequency $\nu_0 = \frac{1}{2\pi}\sqrt{C/\mu}$:

$$\mu \frac{\mathrm{d}^2x}{\mathrm{d}t^2} = -Cx, \qquad -\frac{\hbar^2}{2\mu}\frac{\mathrm{d}^2\psi}{\mathrm{d}x^2} + \frac{1}{2}Cx^2\psi = E_v\psi.$$

- **Quantized vibrational energy eigenvalues:**

$$\boxed{E_{v_k} = \left(v_k + \frac{1}{2}\right)h\nu_0, \qquad g_v = 1 \qquad (v_k = 0, 1, 2, \ldots)}$$

  - Even at $T = 0$ K ($v_k = 0$), the molecule has a nonzero quantum **zero-point energy** $E_0 = \frac{1}{2}h\nu_0$ required by Heisenberg uncertainty.
  - With the harmonic selection rule $\boxed{\Delta v_k = \pm 1}$, vibrational levels are equally spaced by $\Delta E = h\nu_0$ (for CO, $C \simeq 1860$ N m$^{-1}$ gives $\nu_0 \simeq 6.4 \times 10^{13}$ Hz, $\lambda_0 \simeq 4.7\,\mu$m, $\tilde{\nu}_0 \simeq 2143$ cm$^{-1}$).

# Anharmonicity and Combined Ro-Vibrational Transitions

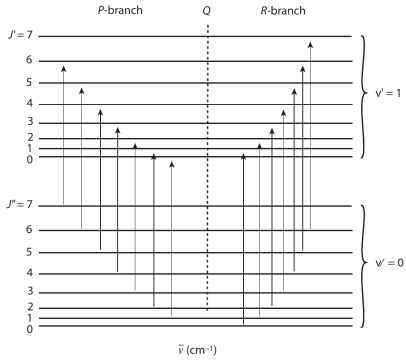



Figure 8: Ro-vibrational transitions between $v = 0$ and $v = 1$ showing the P-branch ($\Delta J = -1$) and R-branch ($\Delta J = +1$). Seager (2010), Fig. 8.6.

- **Anharmonicity in real molecules:** Real internuclear potentials are steeper than a parabola at small $r$ (Coulomb repulsion) and flatten to bond dissociation at large $r$. This **anharmonicity** makes level spacings shrink with increasing $v_k$ and weakly permits **overtone bands** ($\Delta v_k = \pm 2, \pm 3, \ldots$) and **combination bands**.
- **The three ro-vibrational branches:** Because $\Delta E_{\text{vib}} \gg \Delta E_{\text{rot}}$, vibrational transitions ($v \to v+1$) occur simultaneously with rotational transitions ($\Delta J = J_{\text{upper}} - J_{\text{lower}}$), splitting each vibrational band into three branches around $\nu_0$:

$$\begin{aligned} &\textbf{P-branch } (\Delta J = -1): \ \Delta E_P = h\nu_0 - 2BJ \ (\nu < \nu_0) \\ &\textbf{Q-branch } (\Delta J = 0): \ \Delta E_Q = h\nu_0 \ \ (\nu \approx \nu_0) \\ &\textbf{R-branch } (\Delta J = +1): \ \Delta E_R = h\nu_0 + 2B(J+1) \ (\nu > \nu_0) \end{aligned}$$

# Ro-Vibrational Band Structure: Diatomic vs. Polyatomic Molecules

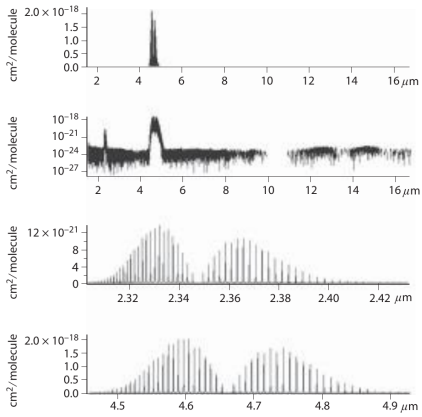



Figure 9: Simulated CO $v = 0 \rightarrow 1$ cross sections at $T = 300$ K, showing the P- and R-branches separated by a central gap at $\tilde{\nu}_0$. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.7.

- **Why the CO fundamental band has a central gap:**
  - For simple heteronuclear diatomics with zero electronic angular momentum along the internuclear axis (CO, HCl, HF), photon angular momentum conservation forbids $\Delta J = 0$ (**no Q-branch**), leaving a zero-opacity gap at $\tilde{\nu}_0$ between the P- and R-branches.
- **Why the P- and R-branches have a double-humped envelope:**
  - Line strength is proportional to the lower-level population $n_J \propto (2J+1)\exp[-BJ(J+1)/(k_B T)]$.
  - As $J$ increases from 0, the degeneracy $(2J+1)$ makes lines grow stronger up to $J_{\max} \approx \sqrt{k_B T/(2B)} - \frac{1}{2}$, before the Boltzmann factor causes an exponential drop-off. Higher $T$ broadens the band outward.
- **When is the Q-branch ($\Delta J = 0$) present?**
  - Polyatomic molecules ($CO_2$, $H_2O$, $CH_4$, $NH_3$) or diatomics with electronic angular momentum (NO) allow $\Delta J = 0$ for vibrations perpendicular to the symmetry axis, producing a sharp central **Q-branch spike** at $\tilde{\nu}_0$ (e.g. the 15 $\mu$m $CO_2$ band).

# Normal Modes of Polyatomic Molecules

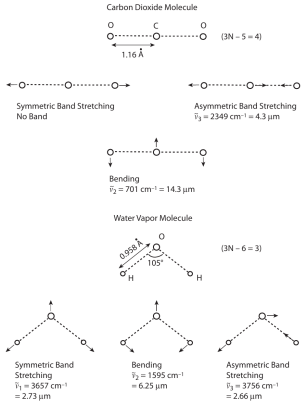



Figure 10: Fundamental normal modes of linear $CO_2$ ($3N-5=4$ modes; $\nu_2$ is doubly degenerate) and bent $H_2O$ ($3N-6=3$ modes). Seager (2010), Fig. 8.8.

- **Counting normal modes of an $N$-atom molecule:** Subtracting 3 translational and 2 (linear) or 3 (nonlinear) rotational degrees of freedom from the $3N$ total degrees of freedom leaves the number of independent fundamental vibrational **normal modes**:

$$N_{\text{vib}} = \begin{cases} 3N-5 & \text{(linear, e.g. } CO_2\text{: 4 modes),} \\ 3N-6 & \text{(nonlinear, e.g. } H_2O\text{: 3; } CH_4\text{: 9).} \end{cases}$$

- **Key greenhouse molecules:**
  - **$CO_2$ (linear):** symmetric stretch $\nu_1$ (1388 cm$^{-1}$, **IR-inactive** because bond dipoles cancel); doubly degenerate bending mode $\nu_2$ (667 cm$^{-1}$, $\lambda = 15\,\mu$m, dominant greenhouse band on Earth, Venus, Mars); asymmetric stretch $\nu_3$ (2349 cm$^{-1}$, $\lambda = 4.3\,\mu$m).
  - **$H_2O$ (bent,** 104.5°**):** symmetric stretch $\nu_1$ (2.73 $\mu$m), bending mode $\nu_2$ (6.27 $\mu$m), and asymmetric stretch $\nu_3$ (2.66 $\mu$m), all strongly IR-active.

# Molecular Electronic Transitions and Photodissociation

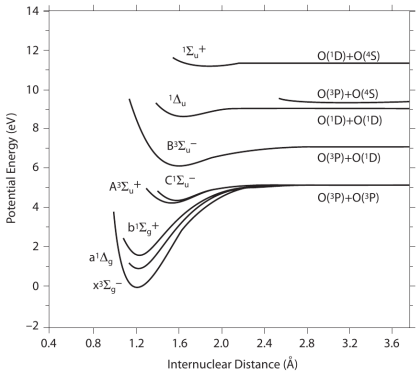



Figure 11: Potential energy curves $E(r)$ for electronic states of $O_2$, illustrating anharmonic vibrational levels and dissociation limits. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.9.

- **Potential energy curves $E(r)$ of electronic states:** Each electronic configuration of a molecule has its own potential curve $E(r)$ supporting a ladder of anharmonic vibrational ($v$) and rotational ($J$) sublevels, so an electronic transition produces an entire system of ro-vibrational bands in the **UV and visible** ($\Delta E_{\rm el} \sim$ few eV).

- **Bound-bound electronic bands in hot exoplanets:**
  - At $T \lesssim 500$ K, molecules reside in their ground electronic state and electronic bands lie in the UV (e.g. $O_2$, $O_3$).
  - In hot Jupiters and brown dwarfs ($T \sim 1500$–$3000$ K), **TiO**, **VO**, FeH, and CrH have low-lying electronic states with strong optical absorption bands that heat the upper atmosphere and drive **thermal inversions**.

- **Photodissociation (bound-free continuum):** UV photons that excite a molecule above the dissociation limit of an upper potential curve break the bond into free atoms (e.g. $O_2 + h\nu \rightarrow O + O$), producing continuous UV opacity.

# Energy Level Populations: LTE vs. Non-LTE Statistical Equilibrium

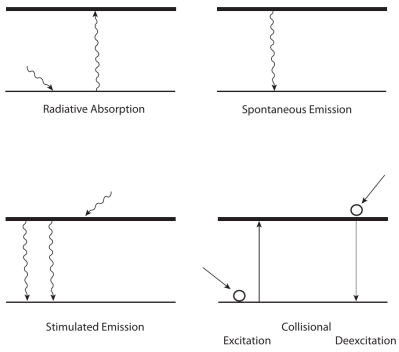



Figure 12: Radiative ($A_{ul}$, $B_{ul}J_{\tilde{\nu}}$, $B_{lu}J_{\tilde{\nu}}$) and collisional ($C_{lu}$,$C_{ul}$) transitions in a two-level system. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.10.

- **LTE populations — Boltzmann distribution:** Where molecular collisions dominate over radiative decay (e.g. $z \lesssim 60$–$70$ km on Earth), level populations follow the **Boltzmann distribution** at local kinetic temperature $T$:

$$\frac{n_j}{n} = \frac{g_j\,\mathrm{e}^{-E_j/k_\mathrm{B}T}}{Q(T)}, \qquad Q(T) \equiv \sum_i g_i\,\mathrm{e}^{-E_i/k_\mathrm{B}T}$$

$$\frac{n_J}{n_0} = (2J+1)\,\mathrm{e}^{-BJ(J+1)/k_\mathrm{B}T}, \qquad \frac{n_v}{n_0} = \mathrm{e}^{-vh\nu_0/k_\mathrm{B}T}.$$

- **Non-LTE statistical equilibrium:** At high altitudes / low pressures where collisions are rare, populations must be solved from **detailed balance** with the mean radiation field $J_{\tilde{\nu}} = \int_0^\infty J_\nu \phi(\nu-\nu_0)\,\mathrm{d}\nu$ via the **Einstein coefficients** $A_{ul}, B_{ul}, B_{lu}$:

$$n_u A_{ul} - n_u B_{ul} J_{\tilde{\nu}} = n_l B_{lu} J_{\tilde{\nu}},$$
$$B_{ul} = \frac{g_l}{g_u} B_{lu}, \qquad A_{ul} = \frac{2h\nu^3}{c^2}\frac{g_l}{g_u} B_{lu}$$

# Molecular Absorption Cross Section and Quantum Line Strength

The monochromatic absorption cross section $\sigma_{lu}(\tilde{\nu})$ ($\mathrm{cm}^2$ $\mathrm{molecule}^{-1}$) for a transition between lower state $l$ and upper state $u$ centered at wavenumber $\tilde{\nu}_0$ factors into a temperature-dependent **line strength** $S_{lu}(T)$ and a normalized **line profile** $f(\tilde{\nu}-\tilde{\nu}_0)$:

$$\sigma_{lu}(\tilde{\nu}) = S_{lu}(T)\, f(\tilde{\nu}-\tilde{\nu}_0), \qquad \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} f(\tilde{\nu}-\tilde{\nu}_0)\,\mathrm{d}\tilde{\nu} = 1, \qquad S_{lu}(T) \equiv \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \sigma_{lu}(\tilde{\nu})\,\mathrm{d}\tilde{\nu}$$

- **Quantum mechanical expression for line strength:** From the microscopic radiative transfer relation $\left[n_l B_{lu} - n_u B_{ul}\right] \frac{h\tilde{\nu}_0}{4\pi c} f(\tilde{\nu}-\tilde{\nu}_0) = n\,\sigma_{lu}(\tilde{\nu})$ in LTE,

$$S_{lu}(T) = \frac{h\tilde{\nu}_0}{4\pi c}\frac{n_l}{n} B_{lu}\left(1 - \mathrm{e}^{-hc\tilde{\nu}_0/k_\mathrm{B}T}\right), \qquad B_{lu} = \frac{8\pi^3}{3h^2 c}\left|\int \Phi_u^* \boldsymbol{\mu}_e \Phi_l \,\mathrm{d}V\right|^2$$

  - The factor $\left(1 - \mathrm{e}^{-hc\tilde{\nu}_0/k_\mathrm{B}T}\right)$ corrects absorption for **stimulated emission** (which acts as negative absorption along the beam).
  - The dipole transition moment integral $\int \Phi_u^* \boldsymbol{\mu}_e \Phi_l \,\mathrm{d}V$ vanishes unless the wave functions have opposite parity, giving the **quantum selection rules** ($\Delta J = \pm 1$ or $0, \pm 1$; $\Delta v = \pm 1$).

# Spectroscopic Line Lists and Temperature Scaling of Line Strengths

- **Why empirical and ab initio spectroscopic databases are needed:**
  - Computing exact wave functions $\Phi_l, \Phi_u$, energy levels $E_i$, and dipole transition moments for polyatomic molecules across millions to billions of ro-vibrational transitions from first principles is extremely challenging.
  - Planetary atmosphere models therefore rely on laboratory measurements combined with quantum mechanical calculations compiled in databases such as **HITRAN** ($T_{\mathrm{ref}} = 296$ K), **HITEMP**, and **ExoMol** (for high-temperature exoplanets and brown dwarfs up to $T \sim 3000$ K).

- **Scaling tabulated line strengths $S_{lu}(T_{\mathrm{ref}})$ to atmospheric temperature $T$:** Using the Boltzmann relation $\dfrac{n_l(T)}{n} = \dfrac{g_l\, \mathrm{e}^{-E_l/k_{\mathrm{B}}T}}{Q(T)}$ in the expression for $S_{lu}(T)$, the unknown Einstein coefficient $B_{lu}$ cancels out in the ratio $S_{lu}(T)/S_{lu}(T_{\mathrm{ref}})$:

$$\boxed{S_{lu}(T) = S_{lu}(T_{\mathrm{ref}})\, \frac{Q(T_{\mathrm{ref}})}{Q(T)}\, \frac{\exp(-E_l/k_{\mathrm{B}}T)}{\exp(-E_l/k_{\mathrm{B}}T_{\mathrm{ref}})}\, \frac{1-\exp(-hc\tilde{\nu}_0/k_{\mathrm{B}}T)}{1-\exp(-hc\tilde{\nu}_0/k_{\mathrm{B}}T_{\mathrm{ref}})}}$$

  where $E_l$ is the lower-state energy, $Q(T)$ is the total internal partition function, and the last ratio accounts for the temperature dependence of stimulated emission.

# Spectral Line Broadening: Natural and Doppler Broadening

Spectral lines are never infinitely sharp $\delta(\nu - \nu_0)$ functions; quantum uncertainty, thermal motions, and intermolecular collisions broaden the line profile $f(\nu - \nu_0)$:

- **1. Natural (radiative) broadening:**
  - An excited state with finite radiative lifetime $\Delta t = 1/A_{ul}$ has an energy uncertainty $\Delta E\,\Delta t \sim h/(2\pi)$ (**Heisenberg uncertainty principle**), yielding a **Lorentz profile** with half-width at half-maximum (HWHM) $\gamma_N$:

$$f_N(\nu - \nu_0) = \frac{1}{\pi}\frac{\gamma_N}{(\nu - \nu_0)^2 + \gamma_N^2}, \qquad \gamma_N = \frac{1}{2\pi\Delta t} = \frac{A_{ul}}{2\pi} \qquad \text{(negligible in planetary atmospheres).}$$

- **2. Thermal (Doppler) broadening:**
  - Thermal line-of-sight velocities $v_z$ follow a 1D Maxwell–Boltzmann distribution $\propto \exp[-mv_z^2/(2k_BT)]$, shifting transition frequencies to $\nu = \nu_0(1 \pm v_z/c)$ and producing a **Gaussian line profile**:

$$\boxed{f_D(\nu - \nu_0) = \frac{1}{\gamma_D\sqrt{\pi}}\exp\left[-\left(\frac{\nu - \nu_0}{\gamma_D}\right)^2\right], \qquad \gamma_D \equiv \frac{\nu_0}{c}\sqrt{\frac{2k_BT}{m}}, \qquad \mathrm{FWHM}_D = 2\sqrt{\ln 2}\,\gamma_D}$$

  - Because $\exp(-x^2)$ drops off rapidly away from $\nu_0$, Doppler broadening dominates near the **line core** and at **low pressures (upper atmosphere)**.

# Spectral Line Broadening: Pressure Broadening and the Voigt Profile

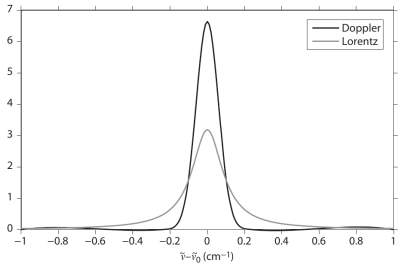



Figure 13: Comparison of a Gaussian Doppler profile and a Lorentzian pressure-broadened profile of equal area and width: the Gaussian is more peaked at line center, whereas the Lorentzian has much broader wings. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.11.

- **3. Collisional (pressure) broadening:** Collisions randomly interrupt the phase of the radiating wave train on mean collision time $\Delta t_{\rm coll}$, yielding a **Lorentz profile** with HWHM $\gamma_{\rm L}$:

$$f_{\rm L}(\nu-\nu_0) = \frac{1}{\pi}\frac{\gamma_{\rm L}}{(\nu-\nu_0)^2+\gamma_{\rm L}^2}, \quad \gamma_{\rm L} = \gamma_{\rm L,0}\left(\frac{P}{P_0}\right)\left(\frac{T_0}{T}\right)^{n_T}$$

($n_T = 0.5$ in kinetic theory; $n_T \approx 0.4$–$0.75$ empirically). Because $(\nu-\nu_0)^{-2}$ decays slowly, Lorentz wings dominate the **line wings** and at **high pressures** ($P \gtrsim 0.1$ **bar**).

- **4. Combined Voigt profile:** Convolution of the Gaussian and Lorentzian profiles:

$$f_{\rm V}(\nu-\nu_0) = \frac{1}{\gamma_{\rm D}\sqrt{\pi}}K(x,y)$$

where $K(x,y) = \frac{y}{\pi}\int_{-\infty}^{\infty}\frac{{\rm e}^{-t^2}}{y^2+(x-t)^2}\,{\rm d}t$ is the **Voigt function** with $x \equiv \frac{\nu-\nu_0}{\gamma_{\rm D}}$ and $y \equiv \frac{\gamma_{\rm L}}{\gamma_{\rm D}}$.

# Line-by-Line Opacity Calculations and Spectral Challenges

- **The computational challenge of line-by-line (LBL) radiative transfer:**
  - In hot planetary atmospheres ($T \sim 1000$–$3000$ K), high thermal excitation populates thousands of vibrational levels. Databases like **HITEMP** and **ExoMol** contain **hundreds of millions to billions of transitions** for $H_2O$, $CO_2$, $CH_4$, CO, TiO, and VO.
  - Resolving the narrow Doppler core and Voigt profile of every individual line requires an ultra-fine wavenumber grid:

$$\Delta\tilde{\nu} \lesssim 10^{-3}\text{–}10^{-2}\ \text{cm}^{-1} \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \sim 10^{6}\text{–}10^{7}\ \text{spectral grid points per spectrum.}$$

  - Direct LBL integration in iterative radiative–convective solvers (requiring hundreds of flux evaluations) or Bayesian MCMC retrievals ($10^5$ forward models) is computationally prohibitive.

- **Line wing cutoff in the far wings:**
  - The standard Lorentzian profile $f_L \propto (\nu - \nu_0)^{-2}$ is derived from the **impact approximation** (assuming collisions are instantaneous and elastic).
  - In the far wings ($|\tilde{\nu} - \tilde{\nu}_0| \gtrsim 25$–$100\ \text{cm}^{-1}$ for molecules; several thousand $\text{cm}^{-1}$ for $H_2$-broadened Na and K resonance lines in hot Jupiters), finite collision duration and interatomic forces cause absorption to drop off exponentially below the Lorentzian prediction (**sub-Lorentzian behavior**), requiring an empirical or quantum wing cutoff ($\chi$-factor).

- **Need for band models and distribution methods:** To accelerate radiative transfer by factors of $10^4$–$10^5$ without sacrificing the precision of quantum line lists, planetary atmosphere models rely on the ***k*-distribution method**.

# The $k$-Distribution Method: Reordering in Frequency Space

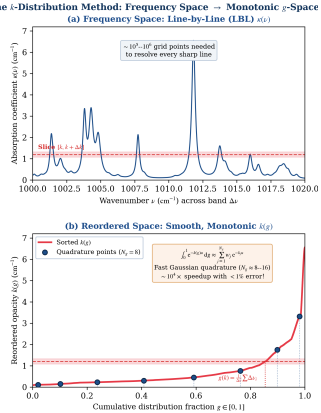



Figure 14: Transformation from oscillating $\kappa(\nu)$ across band $\Delta\nu = 1020 - 1000 = 20\ \mathrm{cm}^{-1}$ to smooth, monotonic $k(g)$.

- **Definitions of key symbols:**
  - $\boldsymbol{\kappa(\nu)}$: Monochromatic absorption coefficient ($\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$) oscillating with $\nu$.
  - $\boldsymbol{u}$: Absorber column density (cm or $\mathrm{g\,cm}^{-2}$; optical depth $\tau = \kappa u$).
  - $\boldsymbol{k}$: Opacity value variable; $\boldsymbol{f(k)}$: probability density of opacity.
  - $\boldsymbol{g(k)} \in [0,1]$: Cumulative fraction of band $\Delta\nu$ where $\kappa(\nu) \le k$: $g(k) \equiv \int_0^k f(k')\,\mathrm{d}k' = \frac{1}{\Delta\nu}\sum_i \Delta\nu_i$. $f(k) = \mathrm{d}g/\mathrm{d}k$.
  - $\boldsymbol{k(g)}$: Reordered, smooth monotonic opacity curve (inverse of $g(k)$).
  - $\boldsymbol{g_j, w_j}$: Gauss–Legendre quadrature evaluation nodes and weights.

- **Frequency invariance of band transmission:**

$$\bar{\mathscr{T}}_{\Delta\nu}(u) = \frac{1}{\Delta\nu}\int_{\Delta\nu} \mathrm{e}^{-\kappa(\nu)u}\,\mathrm{d}\nu = \int_0^\infty f(k)\,\mathrm{e}^{-ku}\,\mathrm{d}k = \int_0^1 \mathrm{e}^{-k\,u}\,\mathrm{d}g$$

- **Fast Gaussian quadrature ($N_g \approx 8$–16, $\sim 10^4\times$ speedup):**

$$\bar{\mathscr{T}}_{\Delta\nu}(u) = \int_0^1 \mathrm{e}^{-k(g)\,u}\,\mathrm{d}g \approx \sum_{j=1}^{N_g} w_j\,\mathrm{e}^{-k(g_j)\,u}$$

# The Correlated-$k$ Method in Inhomogeneous Atmospheres

- **Inhomogeneous vertical paths ($T(z)$, $P(z)$):**
  - In planetary atmospheres, $T$ and $P$ vary continuously with altitude $z$, so optical depth across a layer is $\tau(\nu) = \int \kappa(\nu, T(z), P(z))\, \rho(z)\, \mathrm{d}z$.
  - Because line shapes change with altitude, a simple layer-by-layer $k$-distribution cannot be directly multiplied unless line rank ordering is preserved.

- **The correlated-$k$ approximation (Lacis & Oinas 1991):**
  - We assume the rank ordering of $\kappa(\nu)$ in frequency space is **strongly correlated** across all atmospheric layers:

$$g(\nu, z_1) \approx g(\nu, z_2).$$

  - That is, a wavenumber with high absorption at pressure $P_1$ also has high absorption at pressure $P_2$.
  - This permits calculating optical depth **independently for each $g$-quadrature point**:

$$\tau(g_j) = \int_{z_{\mathrm{bot}}}^{z_{\mathrm{top}}} k(g_j, T(z), P(z))\, \rho(z)\, \mathrm{d}z, \qquad \bar{\mathcal{F}}_{\Delta\nu} \approx \sum_{j=1}^{N_g} w_j\, \mathrm{e}^{-\tau(g_j)}$$

  - The radiative transfer equation is solved once per $g_j$ as a set of standard **pseudo-monochromatic** calculations!

# Correlated-$k$ for Gas Mixtures and Atmospheric Modeling

- **Treating gas mixtures ($\mathbf{H_2O + CO + CH_4 + \ldots}$):**
  - **Random overlap approximation:** If absorption lines of different molecular species are statistically uncorrelated within $\Delta\nu$, total transmission is the product of individual transmissions:

$$\bar{\mathcal{T}}_{\text{mix}} \approx \prod_s \bar{\mathcal{T}}_s = \prod_s \left( \sum_{j=1}^{N_g} w_j \, \mathrm{e}^{-\tau_s(g_j)} \right).$$

  - **Pre-mixed $k$-distribution tables:** For self-consistent 1D/3D exoplanet climate models, opacities are pre-computed on chemical equilibrium grids $(T, P, [\text{Fe/H}], \text{C/O})$, combining all gases into a single composite $k(g)$.

- **Limitations and modern exoplanet applications:**
  - **Breakdown of correlation:** When lines within the same band have widely different lower-state energies $E_l$, their relative strengths change drastically with temperature, introducing errors along steep temperature gradients.
  - **Modern balance:** Correlated-$k$ is the standard for global climate models (GCMs) and fast grid forward models, while GPU-accelerated LBL cross-sections are increasingly used for high-resolution cross-correlation spectroscopy ($R \sim 100{,}000$).

# Rayleigh Scattering by Gas Molecules

When the scattering particle radius is much smaller than the wavelength of light ($r \ll \lambda$, i.e. size parameter $x = 2\pi r/\lambda \ll 1$, as for gas atoms and molecules at UV, visible, and IR wavelengths), scattering is in the **Rayleigh regime**:

- **Physical mechanism — induced oscillating dipole:**
  - The oscillating electric field $E(t) = E_0 \cos(2\pi\nu t)$ of the incident light wave polarizes the electron cloud of a gas molecule, inducing an oscillating dipole moment $p(t) = \alpha_p E(t)$, where $\alpha_p$ is the **molecular polarizability**.
  - By classical electrodynamics, an oscillating dipole radiates scattered electromagnetic power proportional to $\ddot{p}^2 \propto \nu^4 \propto \lambda^{-4}$:

$$\sigma_{\mathrm{Ray}}(\lambda) = \frac{128\pi^5}{3\lambda^4}\,\alpha_p^2 \simeq \frac{8\pi^3}{3\lambda^4}\,\frac{(m^2-1)^2}{n^2}\,F_{\mathrm{K}} \propto \lambda^{-4}, \qquad \alpha_p = \frac{3}{4\pi n}\,\frac{m^2-1}{m^2+2}$$

    where $m(\lambda)$ is the real refractive index of the gas at number density $n$, and $F_{\mathrm{K}} \approx 1$ is the King depolarization factor (accounting for non-spherical molecular anisotropy).

- **Role in planetary and exoplanetary atmospheres:**
  - Because of its steep $\lambda^{-4}$ dependence, Rayleigh scattering by $H_2$, He, $N_2$, $CO_2$, and sub-micron hazes dominates short-wavelength continuum opacity in clear atmospheres — producing Earth's blue sky, high UV/blue geometric albedos, and the characteristic $\lambda^{-4}$ optical slope in exoplanet transmission spectra.

# Rayleigh Scattering Cross Section: Earth's Standard Air

In planetary atmospheric modeling, high-precision empirical polynomial fits replace the idealized dipole approximation. For Earth's standard air, the widely adopted formulation by **Bates (1984)** provides the cross section across UV and optical wavelengths:

- **Empirical cross-section formula** ($0.205 < \lambda < 1.05\,\mu$m)**:**

$$\boxed{\sigma_{\text{Ray,air}}(\lambda) = 10^{-28}\,\lambda^{-4} \sum_{i=0}^{3} a_i\,\lambda^{-2i} \quad [\text{cm}^2/\text{molecule}]}$$

where wavelength $\lambda$ is in $\mu$**m**, with coefficients:

$$a_0 = 3.9729066, \quad a_1 = 4.6547659 \times 10^{-2}, \quad a_2 = 4.5055995 \times 10^{-4}, \quad a_3 = 2.3229848 \times 10^{-5}$$

- **Physical context and characteristics:**
  - Fits dry standard air (78.084% $N_2$, 20.946% $O_2$, 0.934% Ar, 0.033% $CO_2$) with accuracy better than 0.3%.
  - The $\lambda^{-4}$ factor dominates across visible wavelengths, while higher-order $\lambda^{-6}, \lambda^{-8}, \lambda^{-10}$ terms account for refractive index dispersion $(m^2-1)^2$ and the wavelength-dependent King depolarization factor $F_K(\lambda)$.
  - At $\lambda = 0.5\,\mu$m, $\sigma_{\text{Ray,air}} \approx 6.4 \times 10^{-27}$ cm$^2$/molecule.

**Reference:** Bates, D. R. 1984, Rayleigh Scattering by Air, *Planet. Space Sci.*, **32**, 785–790.

# Rayleigh Scattering Cross Section: Molecular Hydrogen ($H_2$)

For hydrogen-dominated atmospheres (gas giants, mini-Neptunes, and hot Jupiters), the standard analytical dispersion formula is given by **Dalgarno & Williams (1962)**:

- **Analytical dispersion formula for $H_2$:**

$$\sigma_{\mathrm{Ray},H_2}(\lambda) = \left( \frac{8.14 \times 10^{-13}}{\lambda^4} + \frac{1.28 \times 10^{-6}}{\lambda^6} + \frac{1.61}{\lambda^8} \right) \quad [\mathrm{cm}^2/\mathrm{molecule}]$$

  where wavelength $\lambda$ is in **Å** ($1\,\text{Å} = 10^{-4}\,\mu\mathrm{m} = 10^{-8}\,\mathrm{cm}$).

  - *Note on units:* Evaluating this analytical formula with wavelength $\lambda$ in Å yields the scattering cross section directly in $\mathrm{cm}^2/\mathrm{molecule}$.

- **Dispersion terms and exoplanetary implications:**
  - The $\lambda^{-6}$ and $\lambda^{-8}$ dispersion terms arise from quantum polarizability approaching the far-UV Lyman-band electronic transitions.
  - At $\lambda = 5000\,\text{Å}$ ($0.5\,\mu\mathrm{m}$), $\sigma_{\mathrm{Ray},H_2} \approx 1.3 \times 10^{-27}\ \mathrm{cm}^2/\mathrm{molecule}$ — roughly **5 times smaller** than air due to the low polarizability of the compact $H_2$ molecule.
  - In clear hot Jupiter atmospheres, this steep $\lambda^{-4}$ slope sets the short-wavelength continuum probe depth ($P \sim 1$–$10$ bar in visible/UV) in transmission spectra.

**Reference:** Dalgarno, A. & Williams, D. A. 1962, Rayleigh Scattering by Molecular Hydrogen, *ApJ*, **136**, 690–692.

# Condensate Opacities: Nature and Physical Characteristics

Beyond molecular gas absorption and Rayleigh scattering, planetary atmospheres contain liquid droplets and solid particles (**condensate clouds** and **photochemical hazes**):

- **Macroscopic aggregates vs. isolated gas molecules:**
  - Gas molecules possess discrete quantum states (electronic, vibrational, and rotational transitions).
  - Condensates are macroscopic molecular aggregates ($10^6$–$10^{15}$ atoms/molecules). Intermolecular bonding suppresses free rotation and blends vibrational modes, producing **smooth absorption and scattering continua** without discrete spectral lines.
- **Ubiquity and composition across atmospheres:**
  - *Solar System:* Liquid $H_2O$ and water ice (Earth), $H_2SO_4$ droplets (Venus), $NH_3$ and $NH_4SH$ (Jupiter), hydrocarbon hazes (Titan).
  - *Exoplanets:* High-temperature refractory minerals (silicates such as $MgSiO_3$, metal oxides $Al_2O_3$, $TiO_2$, and liquid/solid Fe) as well as photochemical soot/tholins.
- **Fundamental governing optical quantities:**
  - **Size parameter** $x \equiv 2\pi r/\lambda$: ratio of particle circumference to wavelength, dictating whether scattering is Rayleigh ($x \ll 1$), resonant Mie ($x \sim 1$), or geometric optics ($x \gg 1$).
  - **Complex refractive index** $m = n_r + in_i$: real part $n_r$ governs phase speed, refraction, and scattering; imaginary part $n_i$ governs material absorption.

# Condensate Opacities: Single-Scattering Phase Functions

When a photon is scattered by a gas molecule or cloud particle, its directional probability distribution as a function of the **scattering deflection angle** $\Theta$ ($\cos\Theta = \hat{\mathbf{n}}_{\rm inc} \cdot \hat{\mathbf{n}}_{\rm scat}$) is given by the **single-scattering phase function** $P(\Theta)$:

$$\frac{1}{4\pi}\int_{4\pi} P(\Theta)\,\mathrm{d}\Omega = \frac{1}{2}\int_{-1}^{1} P(\cos\Theta)\,\mathrm{d}(\cos\Theta) = 1, \qquad g \equiv \langle\cos\Theta\rangle = \frac{1}{4\pi}\int_{4\pi} \cos\Theta\, P(\Theta)\,\mathrm{d}\Omega \in [-1,1]$$

- **Physical meaning of the asymmetry factor $g \equiv \langle\cos\Theta\rangle$:**
  - $g = +1$: pure forward scattering ($\Theta = 0^\circ$); $g = 0$: isotropic or forward–backward symmetric scattering; $g = -1$: pure backscattering ($\Theta = 180^\circ$).
- **Standard analytical phase functions used in radiative transfer:**

$$P_{\rm iso}(\Theta) = 1 \;\; (g = 0), \qquad P_{\rm Ray}(\Theta) = \frac{3}{4}\left(1 + \cos^2\Theta\right) \;\; (g = 0), \qquad P_{\rm HG}(\Theta) = \frac{1 - g^2}{\left(1 + g^2 - 2g\cos\Theta\right)^{3/2}}$$

  - The empirical one-parameter **Henyey–Greenstein phase function** $P_{\rm HG}(\Theta)$ has $\langle\cos\Theta\rangle = g$ by construction and smoothly interpolates between backward ($g < 0$), isotropic ($g = 0$), and strongly forward-peaked ($g > 0$) cloud scattering.

# Condensate Opacities: Geometric Optics Regime

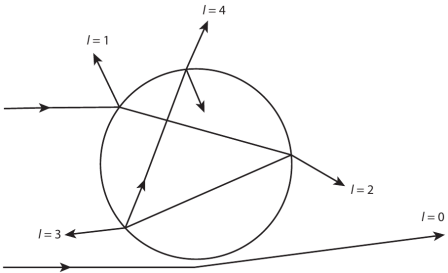



Figure 15: Geometric optics ray paths through a spherical droplet: diffraction ($l = 0$), external reflection ($l = 1$), double refraction ($l = 2$), one internal reflection ($l = 3$, primary rainbow), and two internal reflections ($l = 4$, secondary rainbow). Seager (2010), Fig. 8.12.

- **Why condensate opacities are smooth continua:** Liquid droplets and solid cloud/haze grains (e.g. $H_2O$, $NH_3$, $H_2SO_4$, $MgSiO_3$, Fe, $Al_2O_3$) are macroscopic aggregates in which intermolecular forces lock out free rotation, blending transitions into continuous bands governed by the **size parameter** and **complex refractive index**:

$$\boxed{x \equiv \frac{2\pi r}{\lambda}, \qquad m = n_r + i n_i}$$

($n_r$: phase speed / refraction; $n_i$: damping / absorption).

- **Geometric optics ray tracing ($x \gg 1$, $r \gg \lambda$):**
  - Light rays undergo **diffraction** around the sphere ($l = 0$, forward peak at $\Theta = 0^\circ$ of area $\pi r^2$), **external reflection** ($l = 1$), **two-surface refraction** ($l = 2$), and **internal reflections** ($l \geq 3$).
  - Because both intercepted rays ($\pi r^2$) and diffracted rays ($\pi r^2$) are removed from the beam, a large sphere extinguishes **twice** its geometric area ($\sigma_{\rm ext} \to 2\pi r^2$, $\boxed{Q_{\rm ext} \to 2}$: the **extinction paradox**).

# Droplet Phase Function: Rainbows, Glory, and Mie vs. Geometric Optics

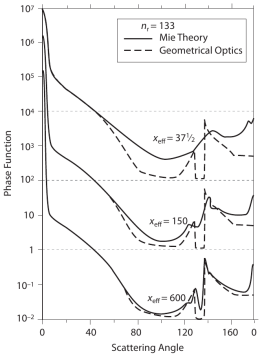



Figure 16: Single-scattering phase function $P(\Theta)$ of water droplets ($x \sim 250$–$500$): exact Mie theory vs. geometric optics. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.13.

- **Comparing Mie theory and geometric optics for large droplets ($x \gg 1$, Fig. 8.13):**
  - **Forward diffraction peak ($\Theta \simeq 0^\circ$):** Diffraction ($l = 0$) and grazing transmission ($l = 2$) produce an intense forward-scattering spike spanning several orders of magnitude in $P(\Theta)$.
  - **Primary and secondary rainbows ($\Theta \simeq 137^\circ$ and $130^\circ$):** For spherical liquid water droplets ($n_r \simeq 1.33$), rays undergoing one internal reflection ($l = 3$) cluster at a minimum deviation angle of $\Theta \simeq 137^\circ$ (**primary rainbow**), while two internal reflections ($l = 4$) cluster at $\Theta \simeq 130^\circ$ (**secondary rainbow**), with **Alexander's dark band** between them.
  - **The Glory ($\Theta \simeq 180^\circ$):** Near exact backscattering ($\Theta \simeq 180^\circ$), surface waves and internally reflected rays interfere constructively to create a sharp backscattering peak called the **glory** — captured by **Mie theory** (solid curve) but missed by geometric optics (dotted curve).
- **Remote-sensing diagnostic:** Rainbow and glory angles in planetary phase curves and polarimetry uniquely identify the refractive index $n_r$ and spherical droplet shape of clouds (e.g. $H_2SO_4$ clouds on Venus).

# The Atmospheric Glory: Physical Mechanism and Observation

The **glory** (광환, 光環) is a wave-optical phenomenon of concentric colored rings centered on the **antisolar point** ($\Theta \approx 180^\circ$), appearing around an observer's shadow on uniform cloud droplets:

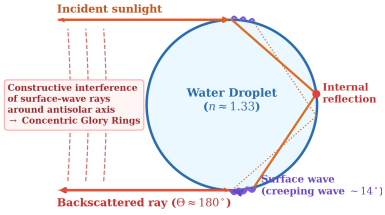



Figure 17: **Formation mechanism:** Surface creeping waves ($\sim 14^\circ$) bridge the geometric gap to $180^\circ$ backscatter.



Figure 18: **Observed glory:** Brocken spectre on mountain clouds, showing concentric interference rings around the antisolar axis.

- **Geometric limit vs. wave optics:** In water ($n \approx 1.33$), one internal reflection deflects grazing rays to at most $\Theta \approx 166^\circ$. Edge rays excite **surface creeping waves** along the droplet perimeter that shed into exact backscatter ($\Theta = 180^\circ$, Nussenzveig 1977).
- **Interference & exoplanet diagnostic:** Rays tunneling around opposite azimuths interfere to form concentric rings. A glory requires spherical droplets with uniform radii (observed on Earth and Venus, and recently inferred on WASP-76b).

# Mie Theory: Exact Solution for Homogeneous Spheres

For spherical particles of any radius $r$ (especially $x = 2\pi r/\lambda \sim 1$, where neither Rayleigh scattering nor geometric optics applies), **Mie theory** gives the exact analytical multipole solution of Maxwell's equations inside and outside a homogeneous sphere of complex refractive index $m = n_r + i n_i$:

$$Q_{\text{scat}} \equiv \frac{\sigma_{\text{scat}}}{\pi r^2} = \frac{2}{x^2}\sum_{n=1}^{\infty}(2n+1)\left(|a_n|^2 + |b_n|^2\right), \qquad Q_{\text{ext}} \equiv \frac{\sigma_{\text{ext}}}{\pi r^2} = \frac{2}{x^2}\sum_{n=1}^{\infty}(2n+1)\,\text{Re}\left(a_n + b_n\right)$$

- **Absorption efficiency and cross section:** $Q_{\text{abs}} = Q_{\text{ext}} - Q_{\text{scat}} \quad \left(\sigma_{\text{abs}} = \sigma_{\text{ext}} - \sigma_{\text{scat}}\right)$.
- **Electric ($a_n$) and magnetic ($b_n$) multipole Mie coefficients:** Expressed in terms of the Riccati–Bessel functions $\psi_n(z) \equiv z\, j_n(z)$ and $\zeta_n(z) \equiv z\,[j_n(z) + i\, y_n(z)]$ of argument $x$ and $mx$:

$$a_n = \frac{\psi_n'(mx)\,\psi_n(x) - m\,\psi_n(mx)\,\psi_n'(x)}{\psi_n'(mx)\,\zeta_n(x) - m\,\psi_n(mx)\,\zeta_n'(x)}, \qquad b_n = \frac{m\,\psi_n'(mx)\,\psi_n(x) - \psi_n(mx)\,\psi_n'(x)}{m\,\psi_n'(mx)\,\zeta_n(x) - \psi_n(mx)\,\zeta_n'(x)}$$

  - The infinite series converges rapidly after $n_{\max} \approx x + 4x^{1/3} + 2$ terms.
  - In the small-particle limit ($x \ll 1$), the $n = 1$ electric dipole term $a_1$ dominates and reproduces **Rayleigh scattering** ($Q_{\text{scat}} \propto x^4 \propto \lambda^{-4}$); in the large-particle limit ($x \gg 1$), it approaches **geometric optics** ($Q_{\text{ext}} \to 2$).

# Mie Scattering Efficiency: Role of Absorption and Size Distribution

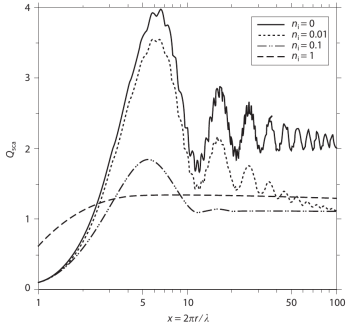



Figure 19: $Q_{\text{scat}}(x)$ for single spheres with $n_r = 1.33$ and $n_i = 0, 0.01, 0.1, 1$. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.14.

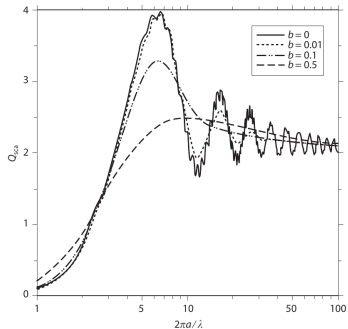



Figure 20: $Q_{\text{scat}}(x)$ integrated over a size distribution of variance $b$. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.15.

- **Interference ripples (Fig. 8.14):** For non-absorbing single spheres ($n_i = 0$), interference between diffracted ($l = 0$) and transmitted ($l = 2$) rays produces large oscillations in $Q_{\text{scat}}(x)$ around the asymptotic limit $Q_{\text{scat}} \to 2$.
- **Damping by absorption ($n_i > 0$):** When $n_i \gtrsim 0.01$, transmitted rays are absorbed inside the sphere, damping out the interference peaks and reducing the large-$x$ limit to $Q_{\text{scat}} \to 1$ (with $Q_{\text{abs}} \to 1$, so $Q_{\text{ext}} \to 2$).
- **Averaging over a size distribution $n(r)$ (Fig. 8.15):**

$$\bar{\sigma}_{\text{scat,ext}} = \frac{\int_0^\infty \sigma_{\text{scat,ext}}(r)\, n(r)\, \mathrm{d}r}{\int_0^\infty n(r)\, \mathrm{d}r}.$$

Realistic cloud size dispersion ($b \gtrsim 0.1$) washes out single-sphere ripples into a smooth curve.

# Optical Properties of Exoplanet Cloud Condensates

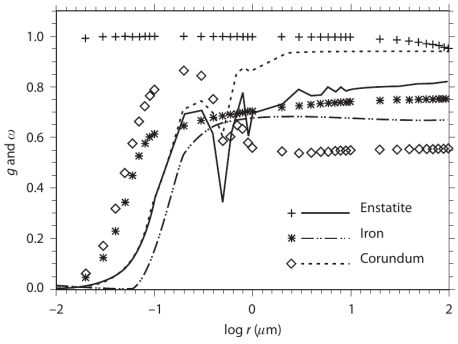



Figure 21: Asymmetry factor $g(\lambda)$ and single-scattering albedo $\omega_0(\lambda)$ for $MgSiO_3$, Fe, and $Al_2O_3$ clouds ($\bar{r} = 1\,\mu$m). Seager (2010), Fig. 8.16.

- **High-temperature exoplanet condensates ($T \sim$ 1200–2000 K, Fig. 8.16):** In hot Jupiters and brown dwarfs, refractory elements condense into mineral and metal clouds with dramatically different single-scattering albedo $\omega_0 = \bar{\sigma}_{\rm scat}/\bar{\sigma}_{\rm ext}$ and asymmetry factor $g$ (shown for $\bar{r} = 1\,\mu$m):
  - **Enstatite ($MgSiO_3$, silicate, $n_i \ll 1$):** nearly pure dielectric scatterer in the optical and near-IR with $\omega_0 \approx 1$ (bright, highly reflective clouds) and strong forward scattering ($g \approx 0.6$–$0.8$).
  - **Corundum ($Al_2O_3$, refractory oxide):** condenses at the highest temperatures ($T \sim 1800$ K), moderately absorbing with intermediate $\omega_0 \approx 0.6$–$0.8$.
  - **Solid/liquid Iron (Fe, metal, $n_i \sim 1$):** strongly absorbing across all wavelengths with low $\omega_0 \approx 0.5$–$0.6$ (dark, low-albedo clouds that efficiently absorb starlight and heat the atmosphere).
- **Drop-off at long wavelengths ($\lambda \gg 2\pi\bar{r}$, $x \ll 1$):** For $\lambda \gtrsim 3$–$5\,\mu$m, $x$ enters the Rayleigh regime ($Q_{\rm scat} \propto \lambda^{-4} \ll Q_{\rm abs} \propto \lambda^{-1}$), causing both $g$ and $\omega_0$ to drop toward zero.

# Structure of Silicate Cloud Condensates

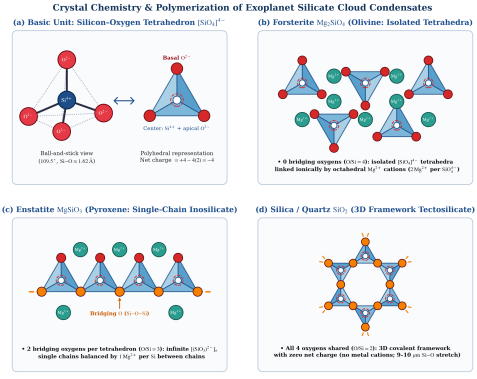



Figure 22: Polymerization of $[SiO_4]^{4-}$ tetrahedra from isolated olivine ($Mg_2SiO_4$) to single-chain enstatite ($MgSiO_3$) and 3D framework silica ($SiO_2$).

- **Basic unit — $[SiO_4]^{4-}$ tetrahedron:** A central $Si^{4+}$ ion is bonded to four $O^{2-}$ ions (109.5°). Silicate minerals are classified by the number of shared corner **bridging oxygens** (Si–O–Si) per tetrahedron:
  - **Forsterite ($Mg_2SiO_4$, olivine / nesosilicate, O/Si $= 4$): 0 bridging oxygens**; isolated $[SiO_4]^{4-}$ units linked by $Mg^{2+}$ ions ($T_{\rm cond} \sim 1500$–$1700$ K).
  - **Enstatite ($MgSiO_3$, pyroxene / inosilicate, O/Si $= 3$): 2 bridging oxygens** per tetrahedron form infinite $[(SiO_3)^{2-}]_n$ single chains balanced by $Mg^{2+}$ ($T_{\rm cond} \sim 1300$–$1500$ K).
  - **Quartz / Silica ($SiO_2$, tectosilicate, O/Si $= 2$): All 4 oxygens shared** in a neutral 3D covalent network.
- **Mid-infrared vibrational bands ($\lambda \sim 8$–$20\,\mu$m):** Transparent in the optical ($\omega_0 \approx 1$), but Si–O stretching (9–11 $\mu$m) and O–Si–O bending (16–20 $\mu$m) modes produce strong mid-IR absorption features (*JWST*/MIRI).

# Scattering Phase Functions of Exoplanet Mineral and Metal Clouds

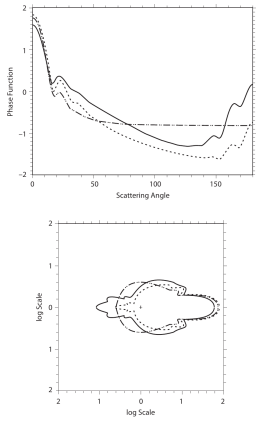



Figure 23: Phase functions $P(\Theta)$ and polar scattering diagrams at $\lambda = 500$ nm for $\bar{r} = 1\,\mu$m condensate clouds ($MgSiO_3$, Fe, $Al_2O_3$). Seager (2010), Fig. 8.17.

- **Directional scattering at $\lambda = 500$ nm, $\bar{r} = 1\,\mu$m ($x = 2\pi\bar{r}/\lambda \simeq 12.6$, Fig. 8.17):**
  - Because $\bar{r} = 1\,\mu$m is larger than $\lambda = 0.5\,\mu$m ($x \gg 1$), all three condensates exhibit an **intense forward-scattering diffraction peak** near $\Theta = 0^\circ$ (spanning more than two orders of magnitude in $P(\Theta)$).
  - **Translucent dielectric grains ($MgSiO_3$, solid; $Al_2O_3$, dashed):** Internal refraction and reflection survive inside low-$n_i$ dielectric particles, producing enhanced side- and back-scattering lobes near $\Theta \sim 140^\circ$–$180^\circ$.
  - **Opaque metallic droplets (Fe, dash-dotted):** Because $n_i \sim 1$, refracted rays are absorbed inside the iron droplet before exiting; scattering is limited to diffraction ($l = 0$) and external reflection ($l = 1$), giving much weaker backscattering.
- **Impact on exoplanet transit spectra:** When $x = 2\pi r/\lambda \gtrsim 1$, cloud extinction is nearly independent of wavelength (**gray opacity**), raising the continuum photosphere to high altitudes and **muting or flattening molecular absorption features**.

# Continuum Opacities in Planetary Atmospheres

In spectral windows between strong molecular bands — or in hot/dense atmospheres — smooth **continuum opacities** control the depth from which photons escape:

- **1. Collision-Induced Absorption (CIA; $H_2$–$H_2$, $H_2$–He, $N_2$–$N_2$, $CO_2$–$CO_2$):**
  - Close binary collisions briefly distort symmetric electron clouds ($\Delta t \sim 10^{-13}$ s), inducing a transient dipole moment that absorbs infrared photons across broad roto-translational and ro-vibrational continua ($\Delta\tilde{\nu} \sim 1/[2\pi c\Delta t] \sim 50$–$500\ \mathrm{cm}^{-1}$).
  - Because CIA is a two-body process ($\alpha_{\mathrm{CIA}} \propto n_1 n_2 \propto P^2$), it dominates the deep infrared opacity of $H_2$–He gas giants, brown dwarfs, cool white dwarfs, and dense $N_2$/$CO_2$ atmospheres (Titan, Venus), forcing deep atmospheres to be convective.
- **2. Bound-free (photoionization and photodissociation) absorption:**
  - A photon with energy $h\nu$ exceeding the ionization threshold $\chi_n$ of an atom/ion (or dissociation energy $D_0$ of a molecule) liberates a free electron (or dissociates the bond), producing continuous absorption at all frequencies $\nu \geq \chi_n/h$ (e.g. H, $H^-$, $O_2$, $O_3$, $H_2O$ UV continua).
- **3. Free-free (bremsstrahlung / inverse bremsstrahlung) absorption:**
  - A free thermal electron passing near an ion or neutral atom/molecule (H, $H_2$, He) absorbs a photon to jump between two unbound continuum kinetic energy states ($\alpha_{\mathrm{ff}} \propto n_e n_{\mathrm{ion}} \nu^{-3}$).
- **4. Negative hydrogen ion ($H^-$) bound-free and free-free opacity:**
  - In ultra-hot Jupiters ($T \gtrsim 2200$ K) and cool stars, thermal ionization of alkali metals supplies free electrons that bind weakly to neutral H atoms ($H^-$ binding energy 0.754 eV, threshold $\lambda \leq 1.64\,\mu$m), making $H^-$ bound-free ($< 1.64\,\mu$m) and free-free ($> 1.64\,\mu$m) the dominant optical/near-IR continuum opacity.

# Summary: Vertical Thermal Structure

- **Hydrostatic equilibrium & scale height:** Pressure supports the atmosphere against gravity, $\mathrm{d}P/\mathrm{d}z = -\rho g$ (or $\mathrm{d}P/\mathrm{d}\tau = g\rho/\kappa$). For an isothermal ideal gas, $P(z) = P_0\,\mathrm{e}^{-z/H}$ with scale height $H = k_\mathrm{B}T/(\mu_m m_\mathrm{H} g)$.
- **Toy greenhouse models:** Energy balance gives $T_s = [2/(2-\alpha)]^{1/4} T_e$ for a single leaky infrared-absorbing layer (absorptivity $\alpha$) and $T_s = (n+1)^{1/4} T_e$ for $n$ opaque layers.
- **Radiative equilibrium & gray T–P profiles:** When radiation dominates, energy conservation requires $\mathrm{d}F_\mathrm{rad}/\mathrm{d}\tau = 4\pi \int \kappa_\nu (J_\nu - S_\nu)\,\mathrm{d}\nu = 0$.
  - Heated from below only (gray, Eddington): $T^4(\tau) = \frac{3}{4} T_\mathrm{int}^4 (\tau + \frac{2}{3})$.
  - Irradiated two-band gray model ($\gamma = \kappa_\mathrm{vis}/\kappa_\mathrm{ir}$): yields greenhouse warming when $\gamma < \sqrt{3}\mu_0$ and a **thermal inversion** when $\gamma > \sqrt{3}\mu_0$.
- **Convection & adiabatic temperature gradient:** When radiative transport is inhibited by high opacity or large flux so that $(-\mathrm{d}T/\mathrm{d}z)_\mathrm{rad} > \Gamma_\mathrm{ad}$, **convection** takes over and sets $-\mathrm{d}T/\mathrm{d}z = \Gamma_\mathrm{ad}$:

$$\Gamma_\mathrm{dry} = \frac{g}{c_p} \quad \left(T \propto P^{R_s/c_p}\right), \qquad \Gamma_\mathrm{moist} = \frac{g}{c_p}\,\frac{1}{1 + (L/c_p)(\mathrm{d}m_s/\mathrm{d}T)} < \Gamma_\mathrm{dry}.$$

- **1D radiative–convective models & retrieval:** Self-consistent forward models iteratively solve hydrostatic equilibrium, radiative transfer, and radiative–convective equilibrium simultaneously for $T(\tau)$, $P(\tau)$, and $I(\tau, \mu, \nu)$. Exoplanet spectral retrievals replace the slow forward solver with a 6-parameter empirical T–P profile to map out allowed temperature structures and molecular abundances.

# Summary: Opacities

- **Atomic & molecular energy hierarchy:** Under the Born–Oppenheimer approximation, $E_{\text{total}} \simeq E_{\text{el}} + E_{\text{vib}} + E_{\text{rot}}$ with $\Delta E_{\text{el}}$ (UV/vis, few eV) $\gg \Delta E_{\text{vib}}$ (near/mid-IR, 0.1 eV) $\gg \Delta E_{\text{rot}}$ (far-IR/microwave, $10^{-3}$ eV).
- **Rotational & vibrational spectra:**
  - **Rigid rotor:** $E_J = BJ(J+1)$ ($B = \hbar^2/[2I]$, $g_J = 2J+1$, $\Delta J = \pm 1$) gives equally spaced lines $\Delta E = 2BJ$.
  - **Simple harmonic oscillator:** $E_v = (v+\frac{1}{2})h\nu_0$ ($\nu_0 = \frac{1}{2\pi}\sqrt{C/\mu}$, $\Delta v = \pm 1$). Combined ro-vibrational transitions split into **P** ($\Delta J = -1$), **Q** ($\Delta J = 0$), and **R** ($\Delta J = +1$) branches across $3N-5$ (linear) or $3N-6$ (nonlinear) normal modes.
- **Line strengths & broadening ($\sigma_{lu}(\tilde{\nu}) = S_{lu}(T)\, f(\tilde{\nu} - \tilde{\nu}_0)$):**
  - **LTE (Boltzmann)** vs. **Non-LTE (statistical equilibrium)** level populations govern $S_{lu}(T)$, scaled from HITRAN/HITEMP/ExoMol via partition functions $Q(T)$.
  - **Doppler broadening** produces a Gaussian core ($\gamma_{\text{D}} = \frac{\nu_0}{c}\sqrt{2k_{\text{B}}T/m}$, low $P$); **collisional broadening** produces Lorentzian wings ($\gamma_{\text{L}} \propto PT^{-n_T}$, high $P$); their convolution is the **Voigt profile**, efficiently integrated using the ***k*-distribution method**.
- **Scattering, clouds, & continuum opacities:**
  - **Gas Rayleigh scattering** ($x \ll 1$) scales as $\sigma_{\text{Ray}} \propto \lambda^{-4}$ with $P_{\text{Ray}}(\Theta) = \frac{3}{4}(1+\cos^2\Theta)$.
  - **Condensate clouds/hazes** ($H_2O$, $MgSiO_3$, Fe, $Al_2O_3$) are governed by $x = 2\pi r/\lambda$ and $m = n_r + in_i$, bridged from Rayleigh ($x \ll 1$) through **Mie theory** ($x \sim 1$) to **geometric optics** ($x \gg 1$, $Q_{\text{ext}} \to 2$, gray clouds).
  - **Continuum opacities** (CIA $\propto P^2$, bound-free, free-free, $H^-$) close spectral windows and drive deep convection.